



HUMANITARIAN INFORMATION MANAGEMENT

Milestones of the Past

- 100 YEARS -

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Humanitarian Information Management of the Past 100 years

This document is part of a personal research project to investigate the evolution of Humanitarian Information Management starting from the time of the League of Nations, when the International Relief Union (IRU) was founded, until the OCHA we know today. The specific aim of this paper is to identify **significant milestones**, providing a framework for future study into the related stories and the innovation behind them.

Although the focus will be on the League of Nations (IRU) and the United Nations (UNDRO, DHA, and OCHA), the list includes innovations involving other organizations when they influenced the wider humanitarian IM discipline. This research does not cover PeaceKeeping, Human Rights, Mine Action, or agency-specific milestones except when they are a clear first in the humanitarian sector.

I hope this research helps current and future IM professionals retrace the origins of the tools and practices they use every day. By understanding our shared history, we can better appreciate the 100 years of progress that have built our professional community.

Pre-1923

While my research focuses on the last century of progress, the roots of modern humanitarian information management (IM) can be traced back to several pivotal moments that fundamentally changed how humanity views and responds to crises.

The Birth of the Modern Disaster: Lisbon, 1755¹

The Great Lisbon Earthquake of 1755 is often cited as the world's first "*modern*" disaster. Occurring during the Enlightenment, it sparked a move away from viewing catastrophes solely as divine punishment toward seeking natural, scientific explanations. Crucially for the IM discipline, this shift led to the systematic collection and study of data - records that remain available in archives today - marking one of the first times a disaster was treated as a data-driven event to be analyzed.

The Origins of Spatial Analysis: John Snow, 1854^{2 3}

A century later, John Snow's mapping of the Broad Street Cholera Outbreak in 1854 provided a masterclass in operational IM. By visualizing the relationship between location and infection, Snow pioneered the use of spatial analysis in humanitarian response. This "*first use of GIS*" demonstrated how structured data and visualization could identify the root cause of a crisis and direct life-saving interventions.

Tragedies of Scale and Evolution^{4 5}

Before the 20th century, the sheer scale of disasters was often defined by geography and infrastructure, such as the 1556 Shaanxi earthquake in China which is often considered the deadliest in human history, claiming an estimated 833,000 lives in a single day. As we entered the 20th century, the nature of these crises began to evolve. While the 1906–1907 Chinese famine was a result of natural flooding, the subsequent decades saw the rise of man-made famines, such as the Great Chinese Famine (1958–1962), where policy and politics replaced weather as the primary driver of catastrophe.

¹ The Great Lisbon Earthquake of 1755, Everything Everywhere Daily podcast, 3 August 2021; Accessed 22 April 2026 ([PDF](#))

² John Snow and the Broad Street Cholera Outbreak of 1854, Everything Everywhere Daily podcast, 16 October 2022; Accessed 22 April 2026 ([PDF](#))

³ *On the mode of communication of cholera (page 45)* by John Snow, 1854 ([PDF](#))

⁴ The Worst Day in Human History: January 23, 1556, Everything Everywhere Daily podcast, 21 January 2025; Accessed 22 April 2026 ([PDF](#))

⁵ A History of Famines, Everything Everywhere Daily podcast, 14 January 2025; Accessed 22 April 2026 ([PDF](#))

Professionalizing Humanitarian Information Management

While these historical events defined the early principles of data and mapping, the formalization of the discipline began in earnest during the League of Nations era. The list below tracks this professional journey, highlighting the markers that have shaped our community over the last 100 years.

Year	Milestones
1923	Raoul Montandon proposes the creation of a single global (colored) map of natural disaster zones⁶ • Black and white maps were included in the proposal⁷ • After a few years of discussions, the map was never produced or printed. Rational: <i>The execution of a single color map on which all calamities would be plotted would require very expensive reproduction processes, so it was necessary to forego it for economic reasons and give a series of separate black and white maps</i>⁸
1924	First publication of the journal <i>Matériaux pour l'étude des calamités</i>⁹
1927	Adoption of the Convention establishing the International Relief Union (IRU)¹⁰ • Aims: In major <i>disasters</i>, the exceptional gravity of which exceeds the powers and resources of the stricken people, furnish <i>first aid</i> and assemble funds, resources and <i>assistance</i> of all kinds; in any public disaster, coordinate efforts made by relief organizations; encourage study of <i>preventive</i> measures against disasters and induce all peoples to render mutual international assistance Dr. Laura H. Martin creates a 32 square foot thematic map of the League of Nations¹¹ • The most significant feature is her use of color and shading to differentiate different nations' relationship to the organization. She distinguishes five levels of status: member nations, areas under League mandate (former German colonies and certain Ottoman provinces), nations not in the League (including the United States), those not in the League but cooperating unofficially (again, including the United States), and those that have signed but not ratified the League Covenant (the United States again). The map is complemented by several tables,

⁶ A propos du projet Cirao. Une carte mondiale de distribution géographique des calamités, Raoul Montandon, Revue Internationale de la Croix Rouge, April 1923 ([PDF](#))

⁷ Montandon's Black and White maps from 1923 by calamity type - from A propos du projet Cirao. Une carte mondiale de distribution géographique des calamités ([PDF](#))

⁸ A propos du projet Cirao. Une carte mondiale de distribution géographique des calamités, Raoul Montandon, Revue Internationale de la Croix Rouge, April 1923 - note on p. 273 ([PDF](#))

⁹ Bibliographie. Etudes de Calamités, made available by the International Review of the Red Cross ([PDF](#))

¹⁰ Convention establishing an International Relief Union, 12 July 1927; Accessed on 18 September 2023 ([PDF](#)); Treaty Series - League of Nations 1923-1933; Accessed on 18 September 2023 ([PDF](#))

¹¹ The League of Nations 1927 map by Dr. Laura H. Martin ([JPG](#))

Year	Milestones
	including one listing member and non-member nations and comparing their relative populations ¹²
1931	Yangtze river floods (China): Perhaps one of the worst ever natural disasters¹³ - Flooding of 180,000 square kilometers of land. This is the equivalent to most of the island of Great Britain or the states of New York, New Jersey, and Connecticut combined - Fatalities have been estimated to be as high as 4,000,000 people First aerial assessment: Charles and Anne Lindbergh conduct aerial reconnaissance and imagery in response to the Yangtze–Huai River floods (China)¹⁴ - Led to the identification of millions of more affected - Delivered aid over the coming days¹⁵
1938	First publication of the <i>Revue pour l'étude des calamités</i> ¹⁶
1971	Creation of the Office of the United Nations Disaster Relief Coordinator (UNDRO)¹⁷ <i>Space Between the Words</i> documentary is put together by the BBC¹⁸ - The ECOSOC negotiations that led to the creation of UNDRO highlight the issue that many countries and agencies were concerned with the extent to which UNDRO would have controlled their actions - The use of the term “<i>direct</i>”, eventually included in the resolution, is heavily discouraged by British diplomats as they found it too strong and intrusive; they suggest the use of “<i>mobilize</i>”, “<i>coordinate</i>” or “<i>instruct</i>”. The US is a strong supporter of the more encompassing “<i>direct</i>”
1973	UNDRO establishes the Information Clearing Centre (section) ¹⁹
1974	UNDRO launches the development of a “<i>data bank</i>”²⁰ containing:²¹ - Information on all developing countries concerning disaster preparedness and all matters relating to eventual relief operations - An index of all potential donors and other sources of such relief supplies, equipment and services - An index of all other pertinent and miscellaneous information

¹² Mammoth League of Nations map from 1927 for sale by Boston Rare Maps, Accessed 18 September 2023 ([PDF](#))

¹³ The Yangtze River, Everything Everywhere Daily podcast, 27 October 2023; Accessed 24 May 2024 ([PDF](#))

¹⁴ Lindberghs Chart Flood Area in China, 22 September 1931, The New York Times; Accessed 18 September 2023 ([PDF](#))

¹⁵ Famished Chinese Imperil Lindbergh; He Escapes in Plane, 27 September 1931, The New York Times ([PDF](#))

¹⁶ Coup d'œil sur la Société de Géographie de Genève de 1908 à 1933, Egmond Goegg, Le Globe. Revue genevoise de géographie, 1933 ([PDF](#))

¹⁷ UN Resolution 2816, 6th December 1971 ([PDF](#))

¹⁸ *Space Between Words - Diplomacy* by BBC, 1971; Accessed 25 April 2026 ([YouTube](#))

¹⁹ Function of the UNDRO Information Clearing Centre and duties of its officers, 2 April 1973 ([PDF](#))

²⁰ Evaluation of the United Nations Disaster Relief Coordinator, 1980, Mark E. Allen, Zakaria Sibahi, and Earl D. Sohm ([PDF](#))

²¹ Function of the UNDRO Information Clearing Centre and duties of its officers, 2 April 1973 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
1975	General Assembly agrees to strengthen UNDRO and calls on the SG to strengthen the office's capacity "including the collection and dissemination of information on disaster assessment, priority needs and donor assistance"²² UNDRO: • Starts UNDRO News²³ • Purchases two portable, high-frequency radio sets for \$90,000²⁴ • Continuously reviews the possible use of transportable earth station satellite equipment²⁵ World Survey of Disaster Damage is launched by UNDRO to obtain quantitative data as part of a project to create an International Strategy for Disaster Prevention. The project is never completed²⁶
1976	UNDRO sets up a dedicated Registry Unit²⁷ • UNOG was not able to provide a rapid or responsive service to the type of work UNDRO was doing
1977	UNDRO sets up dedicated Telecoms room and team²⁸ • SitReps were 20 metres of telex ribbon²⁹ and UNOG Telecom found it bothersome and annoying to send them. So, UNDRO had to setup their own team UNDRO sets out the Terms of Reference for their own Registry and Mail Unit³⁰ UNDRO introduces a standard Subject Classification scheme³¹ ATLANTIS³² - a computer-aided exercise/game for disaster relief management - is launched by Lt. Col. G. N. Ritchie (of the Royal Military College) after 3 years of development by IBM³³. It seems the founder approached UNDRO several times over the years³⁴, but it is unclear if UNDRO ever used the solution
1978	UNDRO starts to see the potential for computers to compose messages³⁵ • The messages were composed and then printed on Telex ribbon for sending

²² Strengthening of the Office of the United Nations Disaster Relief Coordinator, UN. General Assembly (29th sess. : 1974-1975), 1975 - A_RES_3243(XXIX)-EN; Accessed 22 May; ([PDF](#))

²³ Evaluation of the United Nations Disaster Relief Coordinator, 1980, Mark E. Allen, Zakaria Sibahi, and Earl D. Sohm ([PDF](#))

²⁴ Evaluation of the United Nations Disaster Relief Coordinator, 1980, Mark E. Allen, Zakaria Sibahi, and Earl D. Sohm ([PDF](#))

²⁵ Evaluation of the United Nations Disaster Relief Coordinator, 1980, Mark E. Allen, Zakaria Sibahi, and Earl D. Sohm ([PDF](#))

²⁶ World Survey of Disaster Damage: Rapport d'activité, UNDRO, 03.12.1975 ([PDF](#)); Achievements of UNDRO, Geneva 29.08.1978 ([PDF](#))

²⁷ Interviewee 01, May 2023

²⁸ Interviewee 01, May 2023

²⁹ Interviewee 01, May 2023

³⁰ UNDRO Registry and Mail Unit - 30 March 1977 ([PDF](#))

³¹ Introduction of the Subject Classification Manual - 25 August 1977 ([PDF](#))

³² ATLANTIS - A Disaster Simulation Exercise for Training Purposes by Lieutenant Colonel G.N. Ritchie in the Emergency Planning Digest - January-March 1983 ([PDF](#))

³³ The use of computer simulations as a training aid within command courses at the police staff college in Bramshill England - by Chief Superintendent D. J. O'Dowd - June 1981 ([PDF](#))

³⁴ Mission Report by Giles Whitcomb 24-28 June 1985 to Oxford - Shrivenham and London ([PDF](#))

³⁵ Interviewee 01, May 2023

Year	Milestones
	- Arrangement of computers was done with UNICC (who were in the basement of WHO at the time) UNDRO introduces <i>Rules for Correspondence</i> which included a note that all internal communication was to be in English³⁶ First global navigation satellite system launched by the United States called the Global Positioning System (GPS) 1982 - Russia: Global Navigation Satellite System (GLONASS) 2000 - China: BeiDou Navigation Satellite System (BeiDou) 2011 - European Union: Galileo - Ability to leverage these constellations for GIS purposes has a large impact on the humanitarian sector and mapping³⁷ - Smart phones now use these for 'exact' locations³⁸
1979	<i>Natural Disasters and Vulnerability Analysis</i> outlines data needed by disaster type³⁹ This may have been a precursor to the first Global Assessment Report (GAR) by UNDRR (then ISDR) in 2009, which was itself the basis for the INFORM analytical framework⁴⁰
1980	UNDRO holds the first Inter-Organization Meeting for Information Interchange to share information about the use of computers in disaster preparedness, prevention, and relief⁴¹ - Conceived as the first step towards inter-organizational exchange of data⁴² UNDRO using an IBM mainframe, managed by UN International Computing Centre (ICC) UNDRO connects to the ICC by means of a remote video display terminal ('VDU') in the UNDRO Co-ordination Centre⁴³ - ICC has an IBM 3033 computer with 12 megabytes of main memory, 30 disc drives for auxiliary memory, and 12 magnetic tape drives - ICC also has an IBM 370/158 computer with 4 MB memory UNDRO uses these computers to run the 'SENDTLX' programme allowing a Telex, composed on the VDU screen using Wyllbur Text Editing System, to be sent to as many as 150 addresses automatically⁴⁴ - Primarily used to send UNDRO Sit Reps - Connected to UN's computerized message switching system (UNMESS II)

³⁶ Office Rules for Correspondence - Memorandum - 31 March 1978 ([PDF](#))

³⁷ Interviewee 02, August 2023

³⁸ Interviewee 02, August 2023

³⁹ Natural Disasters and Vulnerability Analysis - Report of Expert Group Meeting, 1979, Office of the United Nations Disaster Relief Co-ordinator (UNDRO) ([PDF](#))

⁴⁰ Written Respondent 01 received 17 March 2023

⁴¹ UNDRO correspondence, 31 October 1980; other meetings are held in 1981 and 1982 ([PDF](#))

⁴² Report on Inter-organization Meeting for Information Interchange, UNDRO, 11 November 1980 ([PDF](#))

⁴³ Report on Inter-organization Meeting for Information Interchange, UNDRO, 11 November 1980 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁴ Report on Inter-organization Meeting for Information Interchange, UNDRO, 11 November 1980 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	UNDRO computer systems:⁴⁵ • UNDCON: a computer system that processes and print contributions (including summaries) made for a given disaster • UNDSORT: prints reports of contributions by type of aid item (e.g. food, shelter) and by type of organization (govt, NGO, etc) • UNDPRI: prints the input to UNDCON and UNDSORT • Directory: contains practical and administrative information useful in a disaster • Disaster Alert List: contains basic information on disasters as soon as they occur • Sitrep Data Sets: prints reports containing all situations reports produced by UNDRO • Meeting List: contains all UNDRO Coordination Centre meetings • Phone List: contains the phone numbers of all UNDRO staff • Monthly Conference List: contains all conferences that may be of interest to staff UNDRO Data Bank contains a map library
1981	Disaster History Database was built on index cards by UNDRO⁴⁶
1982	Mobile Disaster Units (MDU)⁴⁷ - first meeting held in Geneva • How/who conducts primary assessments • Sharing of information for Sit Reps UNDRO establishes a Relief Co-ordination and Information Center in Chad in collaboration with their <i>Ministère de la lutte contre les calamités</i>⁴⁸ • Swiss Government Disaster Relief Unit (SDRU) involved University of Wisconsin-Madison Disaster Management Center (UWDMC) begins offering a Disaster Management Diploma⁴⁹ in conjunction with UNDP and UNDRO^{50 51} • UWDMC was part of the Department of Engineering Professional Development, College of Engineering • First <i>Disaster management Training Programme</i> Trainers Workshop was held in March 1982

⁴⁵ Report on Inter-Organization Meeting for Information Interchange, UNDRO, 11 March 1981 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁶ Interviewee 03, May 2023

⁴⁷ MDU was defined by UNDRO as "an organized group, whether governmental or non-governmental, which stands ready to engage itself in relief activities, at disaster sites outside its country of origin"

⁴⁸ The 'RICSU' Concept: Computers that ease human misery, UNDRO News, July/August 1985 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁹ UWDMC website accessed on 25 August 2023 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁰ Interview with Kaz (Kazuhide) Kuroda on 29 March 2023

⁵¹ DMTP Trainers Workshop - University of Wisconsin-Madison - certificate for Kaz Kuroda - March 1992 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
1984	UNDRO procures a special telephone system in France, for their emergency system, as the Swiss system can only connect 11 phones⁵² UNDRO experiments with Argos transmitter in disaster relief operations^{53 54} • The device weighs 8 kg, is powered by six 4.5 V batteries, has a keyboard with 10 numeric and six control keys and a 256 bit message length. It is carried in an aluminum suitcase. Messages, once entered, are broadcast once every 55 sec until one of two NOAA satellites passes overhead, receives the message, imprints it with a nearest equator-crossing time stamp, and relays it when passing over a NOAA ground station UNDRO installs a system of pigeon holes to help streamline delivery of documents⁵⁵ UNDRO begins a two year project, leveraging personal computers and Lotus 123, to try to track and match needs with contributions. After 2 years, a proof-of-concept was in place, but input (needs) and reporting (contribution) delays meant the project did not advance⁵⁶ Second meeting on Mobile Disaster Units held in Geneva⁵⁷ • UNDRO has a repository of data base profiles of MDUs, including their past activities, and acts as a point of reference for information sharing among MDUs • Information was collected in the field by a small team and then transmitted by radio to Switzerland prior to the departure of the full mission (Swiss Disaster Relief Unit) • The UNDRO Data Bank contains copies of disaster emergency plans for approximately forty countries. These are reflected in country profiles drawn up by UNDRO Indonesia: UNDRO's <i>Strengthening Disaster Preparedness and Disaster Management in Indonesia</i> project formulation missions recommends:⁵⁸ • Integrated Disaster Communications and Information Flow Management System • Establishment of a National Disaster Management Institute • Compilation of a Disaster Management Organization and Procedures Handbook, and • Establishment of an integrated risk monitoring mechanism

⁵² UNDRO secretarial meeting notes, Geneva 19 November 1984 - retrieved from UN archives on 15.03.2023 ([PDF](#))

⁵³ UNDRO/CNES experiments in the use of an Argos transmitter in disaster relief operations, Harvard Astrophysics Data System - SciX Transition Resources, Accessed 25 April 2026 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁴ Interview with Kaz (Kazuhide) Kuroda on 29 March 2023

⁵⁵ UNDRO secretarial meeting notes, Geneva 05 November 1984 - retrieved from UN archives on 16.03.2023 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁶ Interview with Kaz (Kazuhide) Kuroda on 29 March 2023

⁵⁷ Final Report on the International Meeting on Mobile Disaster Units, 22-24 May 1984, UNDRO ([PDF](#))

⁵⁸ Preparedness Mission of Giles Whitcomb - PHI-INS-ASEAN - January 1985 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
1985	FEWS.NET (Famine Early System) is created by USAID⁵⁹ • Now used for food insecurity warning • A precursor of IPC - Integrated Phase Coordination⁶⁰ Mexico City earthquake: deployment team from UNDRRO rarely leaves the hotel room. Watched TV news and read local newspapers to develop reports for Geneva⁶¹ • Greatly influenced the early concept of the future UNDAC team • Situation reports were drafted and published by Geneva. Clear frustration of how little input was included from the field (submitted to HQ by telex)⁶² • Communication by Telex was challenging. Often garbled to the point they would joke with either other: ◦ <i>"But unfortunately it's garbled again. Best hand type it old man"</i>⁶³ • "UNDRRO had little in the way of co-ordination activities to offer to Mexico City. Its primary purpose during this disaster was the dissemination of information to the press, the public and the donors."⁶⁴ • Suggestion from UNDRRO deployee that UNDRRO acquire the same radio as used by PAHO to improve future emergency communications. The radio weighed about 15 kilos, could be operated with a car battery and reached anywhere in the world via satellite. Approximate cost of US\$ 2,000⁶⁵ • Given significant unnecessary aid and the belief that donors send aid spontaneously before consideration of needs assessment, it was suggested that a list could be distributed to donors describing relief needs according to country and potential disaster. And, that UNDRRO could work to educate donors on the importance of determining needs before making contributions⁶⁶ • Mission summary mentioned that "...with the efforts UNDRRO has been making responding to long-term disasters in Africa, the Office may have lost some of its ability to react and respond to short-term disasters such as the Mexico earthquake" It was recommended that UNDRRO begin to make adjustments to better prepare itself for this type of disaster⁶⁷ UNDRRO installs a computer terminal (WANG⁶⁸) in New York so as to provide immediate two-way communication of data and documents between UNDRRO Headquarters in Geneva and the New York Liaison Office⁶⁹

⁵⁹ FEWS Website - About Us, accessed on 25 April 2026 ([PDF](#)); Interviewee 04, March 2023

⁶⁰ Written Respondent 01 received 24 March 2023

⁶¹ Interviewee 05, June 2023

⁶² Report of Mission for Mexico earthquake by Julio C Grieco on 11 December 1985 ([PDF](#))

⁶³ Telexes sent from Mexico City during the mission - See Annex 1 of Report of Mission for Mexico earthquake by Julio C Grieco on 11 December 1985 ([PDF](#))

⁶⁴ Mexico Earthquake Debriefing in UNDRRO Coordination Room in Geneva on 12 November 1985; Notes by Timothy Lake; See Annex 2 of Report of Mission for Mexico earthquake by Julio C Grieco on 11 December 1985 ([PDF](#))

⁶⁵ Mexico Earthquake Debriefing in UNDRRO Coordination Room in Geneva on 12 November 1985; Notes by Timothy Lake; See Annex 2 of Report of Mission for Mexico earthquake by Julio C Grieco on 11 December 1985 ([PDF](#))

⁶⁶ Mexico Earthquake Debriefing in UNDRRO Coordination Room in Geneva on 12 November 1985; Notes by Timothy Lake; See Annex 2 of Report of Mission for Mexico earthquake by Julio C Grieco on 11 December 1985 ([PDF](#))

⁶⁷ Mexico Earthquake Debriefing in UNDRRO Coordination Room in Geneva on 12 November 1985; Notes by Timothy Lake; See Annex 2 of Report of Mission for Mexico earthquake by Julio C Grieco on 11 December 1985 ([PDF](#))

⁶⁸ Interviewee 06, April 2023

⁶⁹ UNDRRO at work, UNDRRO News, January/February 1985 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	• Geneva had two WANG computers - one in the Office of the Director and one in the Officer of Administration⁷⁰ Relief Information and Coordination Support Unit (RICSU) established by UNDRO in collaboration with the Sudanese government^{71 72} • Two micro-computers that were connected by modem to UNDRO's mainframe in Geneva • Software adapted to (1) manage data on international relief contributions, (2) enable word processing to update and disseminate operational information, and (3) transmit computerized data to Geneva • Located in Sudan's Department of Social Welfare; UK funded • Setup by Giles Whitcomb, Consolidation: Nicolas Russell, Development: Tony Hughes UNDRO has three people in Geneva managing multiple telex machines to handle incoming messages and news⁷³ • Outgoing messages were put into a computer application and the telex then sent • A special 'beep' would mean someone was online and a response could be sent immediately • UNOG handled emergency messages at nights and weekends; UNOG would reach out to UNDRO Duty Officer • Staff used "Le TUBE" (Pneumatic Tube) to send messages around the office. If something was labeled '6', it would automatically go to the Coordination Centre, land loudly in a big plastic bin and be treated urgently⁷⁴ UNDRO managed a contacts database of major press agencies and newspapers. SitReps were sent to this list in order to inform press of actions taken by UNDRO and needs⁷⁵ OEOA (Office for Emergency Operations in Africa) and UNDRO jointly create an Information Processing Unit⁷⁶ • OEOA established a working Group for which UNDRO was providing the leading input of emergency data⁷⁷
1986	UNDRO settles on the idea of (just) tracking financial transactions. This work eventually led to the modern day Financial Tracking Service⁷⁸ UNDRO establishes a local data management system in Mozambique⁷⁹

⁷⁰ Interviewee 06, April 2023

⁷¹ The 'RICSU' Concept: Computers that ease human misery, UNDRO News, July/August 1985 ([PDF](#))

⁷² UNDRO Mission Report - Sudan Drought Emergency - June, 1985 ([PDF](#))

⁷³ Interviewee 06, April 2023

⁷⁴ Interviewee 06, April 2023; Written Respondent 02 received 11 April 2023

⁷⁵ Interviewee 06, April 2023

⁷⁶ OEOA/UNDRO Note, 1 Feb 1985 ([PDF](#))

⁷⁷ OEOA correspondence, 29 January 1985 ([PDF](#))

⁷⁸ Interviewee 07, March 2023

⁷⁹ Interviewee 07, March 2023

Year	Milestones
	Agencies are starting to use Lotus 123 to track, but not match, needs and contributions⁸⁰ UNDRO's Bibliographical data base is considered complete. The Master Distribution and Country Profile data bases are still in progress⁸¹
1987	Office for Research and Collection of Information (ORCI), part of UNDRO, establishes an early warning system⁸² • It ran for 5 years, but was not popular with the member states as they thought the UN was keeping secrets⁸³ • Intentions: monitor global trends; geographical profiles; early-warning; maintain information in data systems and data banks; monitor factors affecting refugee flow, and ad hoc needs assessments⁸⁴ Internet: In Ethiopia, the Resident Representative (RR), Deputy RR, and Chief of Emergency Prevention & Preparedness note that it will have major impacts on their work and information sharing.⁸⁵ • The field expected they would be directed by HQ: <i>"with this internet stuff, we are going to lose all control over our field offices"</i>
1988	Emergency Events Database (EM-DAT) launched by the Centre for Research on the Epidemiology of Disasters (CRED)⁸⁶ UNDRO launches the International Disaster Management Information Network - UNDRONET⁸⁷ UNDRO creates the United Nations International Emergency Network, UNIENET⁸⁸ UNDRO's computerized system for worldwide distribution of disaster situation reports (SITREPS) improves from some 50,000 copies sent in 1984-1985 to approximately 65,000 in 1987-1988⁸⁹ Armenia Earthquake response leads to the eventual creation of UNDAC and INSARAG⁹⁰ • Consultants were hired to develop the concept & first trainings

⁸⁰ Interviewee 07, March 2023

⁸¹ UNDRO at work, UNDRO News, January/February 1986 ([PDF](#))

⁸² ST SGB 225 - Creation of the Office for Research and Collection of Information, 1 March 1987, Accessed 25 April 2026 ([PDF](#))

⁸³ Interviewee 08, March 2023

⁸⁴ ST SGB 225 - Creation of the Office for Research and Collection of Information, 1 March 1987, Accessed 25 April 2026 ([PDF](#))

⁸⁵ Interviewee 09, March 2023

⁸⁶ EM-DAT Website, accessed on 26 April 2026 ([PDF](#))

⁸⁷ ECOSOC Second regular session, 1 June 1988 ([PDF](#))

⁸⁸ The involvement of the United Nations System in Providing And Coordinating Humanitarian Assistance - Erica-Irene Does - Joint Inspection Unit - 1995 ([PDF](#))

⁸⁹ ECOSOC Second regular session, 1 June 1988 ([PDF](#))

⁹⁰ Interviewee 05, June 2023

Year	Milestones
1990	General Assembly designates the 1990s as the International Decade for Natural Disaster Reduction⁹¹ Early 1990s: • UNDRO/DHA field reports were submitted to HQ by satellite phones (C-band) or fax (if available)⁹² • Laptops are introduced in the field making IM work more portable⁹³
1991	UN General Assembly adopts resolution 46/182 creating the blueprint for today's international humanitarian system.^{94 95} Results in the creation of things (directly and indirectly) such as: • Emergency Response Coordinator position • Inter-Agency Standing Committee • Central Emergency Response Fund • Consolidated Appeals Process • UNDAC • ReliefWeb • Financial Tracking Service, etc. Coded fax machines, in a secure basement room of the Palais, used to send information to UNDRO in Iraq⁹⁶ UNDRO recognizes the increasing importance of managing information/data and its increasing speed in <i>UNDRO in the 1990s - The role and the plan - An Overview</i>. They also correctly predict the scale of future disasters⁹⁷ • Key area of UNDRO's work: Information exchange, awareness raising and transfer of knowledge on disaster-related matters • UNDRO recognizes that disasters are changing as a result of things like climate change. They expect to see more frequent mega-disasters (i.e. disasters with tens of thousands of victims and costs in the hundreds of millions of dollars). And that global awareness will be high and immediate given the speed and ubiquity of communication which will greatly strengthen the dissemination and impact of media reports • UNDRO plans to establish a 24-hour Operations Center which will facilitate the inclusion of staff of other agencies. Aim is to give key international actors access to real or near-real time information for operational decision making UNDRO launches SEISMED, an initiative involving all Mediterranean countries aimed at collecting local seismic vulnerability assessments and turning them into disaster management plans⁹⁸

⁹¹ International Decade for Natural Disaster Reduction (IDNDR) Correspondence, 11 January 1994 ([PDF](#))

⁹² Interviewee 10, March 2023

⁹³ Interviewee 11 mentioned mentioned the Red Cross sending laptops in 1992/93, March 2023

⁹⁴ UN General Assembly Resolution 46-184 - Strengthening of the coordination of humanitarian emergency assistance of the United Nations - 1991 ([PDF](#))

⁹⁵ OCHA on Message: General Assembly resolution 46/182 [EN/AR], 1 March 2012 ([PDF](#))

⁹⁶ Interviewee 12, March 2023

⁹⁷ UNDRO in the 1990s - The role, the plan: An Overview - October 1991 ([PDF](#))

⁹⁸ DHA/UNDRO fax, 08 June 1992 ([PDF](#)); UNDRO correspondence, 05 February 1992 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	- It was born from a 1985 seminar on UNDRO's approach on seismic reduction - It aimed at building an "information (data) base" from questionnaires on seismic vulnerability distributed to experts from Mediterranean countries - Results were used in 3 workshops conducted over the period 1990-1992
1992	UNDRO becomes the Department of Humanitarian Affairs (DHA)⁹⁹ Geographical Information System - DHA uses GIS in Mozambique, collaborating with other agencies and NGOs¹⁰⁰ - Cambodia Mine Action (CMAC) leveraging GIS to map mine files¹⁰¹ Project IERRIS (International Emergency Readiness and Response Information System) initiated by UNDRO/DHA Geneva¹⁰² - Abandoned by 1995 after a cost of at least \$0.5 million¹⁰³ - Becomes basis for HCWEB (1995) Financial Tracking Service launched by DHA¹⁰⁴ UNHCR Cambodia ordered SPOT (satellite) imagery to identify overgrown agricultural land in hopes to give it to returning refugees¹⁰⁵ - Imagery captured, but not used as intended as the project had not thought through the factors of who owned the land previously and what would happen when sending refugees to mined land IFRC started typing up their refugee cards in the field which could be faxed to HQ resulting in fewer transcription errors.¹⁰⁶ Recognition of the importance of data and its structure
1993	UNDAC (United Nations Disaster Assessment and Coordination) is established by DHA¹⁰⁷ DHA drafts a <i>Disaster Management Manual</i> with UNDP¹⁰⁸ Distribution of NDVI GIS data by FEWS over FTP¹⁰⁹ Creation of RwandaNet, the predecessor of what was going to be (unsuccessfully)

⁹⁹UN General Assembly Resolution 46-184 - Strengthening of the coordination of humanitarian emergency assistance of the United Nations - 1991 ([PDF](#))

¹⁰⁰ Geographical Information Systems and the Management of Humanitarian Programmes, Alistair Hallam, 1 June 1996 ([PDF](#))

¹⁰¹ Interviewee 13, March 2023

¹⁰² Giles Whitcomb - brief professional CV - 1998 ([PDF](#))

¹⁰³ The involvement of the United Nations System in Providing And Coordinating Humanitarian Assistance - Erica-Irene Does - Joint Inspection Unit - 1995 ([PDF](#))

¹⁰⁴ Internet Archive - WayBackMachine, capture of FTS on ReliefWeb from 12 March 2000 ([PDF](#))

¹⁰⁵ Interviewee 13, March 2023

¹⁰⁶ Interviewee 11, March 2023

¹⁰⁷ This is UNDAC - Brochure, 2025 ([PDF](#))

¹⁰⁸ Giles Whitcomb - brief professional CV - 1998 ([PDF](#))

¹⁰⁹ Written Respondent 06 received 9 March 2023

Year	Milestones
	ReliefNet, and eventually ReliefWeb¹¹⁰ Bosnia: DHA used a tool called Disaster Assistance Logistics Information System (DALIS) - built in FoxPro. The system was originally developed for Operation Provide Comfort in 1991 and came to DHA via OFDA¹¹¹
1994	Rwanda Genocide - United Nations Rwanda Emergency Office (UNREO) was created by DHA¹¹² • Following consultations among the UN Assistance Mission for Rwanda (UNAMIR) and the ICRC, it was agreed that DHA would take the lead role in organizing and overseeing the activities of UNREO and thus for supervising the work of the United Nations as well as Governments and NGOs • Working first from Nairobi and then from Kigali as of July 1994, UNREO served as the nexus for information collection and dissemination throughout the area of operation • UNREO and UNAMIR had the Humanitarian Assistance Cell (HAC) ◦ Created a precursor of 3W called the <i>Matrix</i>^{113 114 115} ■ Started in Microsoft Word, moved to Microsoft Excel and eventually to a database¹¹⁶ (by a couple backpacking New Zealanders¹¹⁷ or a couple Austrian military officers¹¹⁸) ■ Print outs got responders attention; People would come like 'clock-work' to pick up the report each week¹¹⁹ ◦ Seemed to have databases for different activities (sometimes in conjunction with IOC)¹²⁰ • Pigeon-holes were set up for everyone in the UNDP compound next to the round-about driveway. On Matrix-day, people would drive in, run to their pigeon-hole, run back to their vehicle, and leave¹²¹ • UNMIR drawing on paper maps for operational purposes¹²² • UNREO-DHA planned locations across Rwanda with the use of maps provided by DeLorme (1993)¹²³ • UNREO establishes the Integrated Operations Centre (IOC) ◦ Operated under the guidance of the IOC Task Force which included the UN Mission, most UN Agencies, the Red Cross and NGO representatives¹²⁴ ◦ IOC database produced 3W-like reports → outputs simply say "List of organizations operating in <i>locationname</i>"¹²⁵ ◦ Creates the first inter-agency humanitarian database that used

¹¹⁰ Interviewee 14, March 2023; *ReliefWeb's Early Days* by Craig Duncan, 10 August 2021 ([PDF](#))

¹¹¹ Interviewee 15, May 2023

¹¹² United Nations Rwanda Emergency Office Humanitarian Situation Reports, 1994 ([PDF](#))

¹¹³ Interviewee 16, July 2023; Written Respondent 03 received 21 July 2023

¹¹⁴ Inter Office Memorandum from HAC Ops to UNREO on 24 Nov 94 notes "Matrix indicates that no agencies are present in this commune" [Nyamyumba Commune] ([PDF](#))

¹¹⁵ The International Response to Conflict and Genocide - Lessons from the Rwanda Experience - Study 3 - Humanitarian Aid and Effects ([PDF](#))

¹¹⁶ Letter from HAC to 'All Sec Hum Offrs' titled 'HAC Database' on 15 June 1995 ([PDF](#))

¹¹⁷ Interviewee 16, July 2023

¹¹⁸ Written Respondent 04 received on 25 August 2023

¹¹⁹ Interviewee 16, July 2023

¹²⁰ Rwanda HAC Database - Request for Sucker Truck - September 1995 ([PDF](#))

¹²¹ Interviewee 16, July 2023

¹²² Humanitarian assistance (Item S-1062-0163-0005-00002) as part of *United Nations Assistance Mission for Rwanda (UNAMIR) (1993-1996)* ([PDF](#))

¹²³ Map of Rwanda planned locations, DHA, DeLorme Mapping 1993 ([PDF](#))

¹²⁴ IOC Taskforce and draft TORs for all positions, 24 May 1995 ([PDF](#))

¹²⁵ List of organizations operating in Gisenyi - IOC Database Production - 14 Oct 1995 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	digital mapping in Rwanda¹²⁶ ○ An American NGO, ResponseNet, assists with the creation of an integrated humanitarian database. This uses digital mapping to display humanitarian data, enabling government and participating organisations to identify gaps in assistance and any areas of overlap ● Leveraged DeLorme Mapping technology ● Funded by and staffed by the Swedish government¹²⁷ ● Officially closed in October 1995 WHO Rwanda develops the Système d'Information Épidémiologique au Rwanda (MS Access and ArcView). It combined a database with an automatic map maker to enable spatial epidemiological analyses¹²⁸ US State Department's Office of the Geographer and Global Issues proposed a crisis information sharing network called ReliefNet.¹²⁹ The idea suggested a menu-driven database on the Internet with the below categories (per crisis-prone country). This idea led to the establishment of ReliefWeb ● Maps and General Background ● Groups at risk (IDPs and refugees) ● Public health ● Food/Water ● Disasters ● Political/Civil unrest ● Economy ● Logistics ● Disputes ● Experts and Key relief agencies ● Bulletin board ● Help Gopher distribution of WFP information¹³⁰ WFP establishes the Vulnerability Analysis and Mapping (VAM) Unit in Rome. The founder later becomes the founder of OCHA's Field Information Services Section (FIS)¹³¹ ● Responders in the early IM space became aware of each other and recognized that they could work together and share information without creating real competition for financial resources. This approach and knowledge led to FIS and the Humanitarian Information Centers (HICs) ● IM-related teams, from various entities, co-located, collaborated and supported each other ● The creation of Vulnerability Analysis and Mapping (VAM) was accidental rather than the outcome of a well planned, systematic, researched and thoughtful procedure¹³²

¹²⁶ Humanitarian Assistance Cell (HAC) - Integrated Operations Centre (IOC) - Operation Retour reports, 15 February 1995 ([PDF](#))

¹²⁷ Interviewee 16, July 2023

¹²⁸ Guide D'Utilisation - Système d'Information Épidémiologique au Rwanda ([PDF](#)); Written Respondent 05 received 29 July 2023

¹²⁹ Proposal for a Crisis Information Sharing Network - ReliefNet - Fax from William Wood and Don Krumm from the Office of the Geographer and Global Issues in the US State Department - 26 September 1994 ([PDF](#))

¹³⁰ Written Respondent 06 received on 09 March 2023

¹³¹ Interviewee 17, March 2023

¹³² *The Birth and Growth of Vulnerability Analysis and Mapping* by Pablo Recalde, 2018

Year	Milestones
1995	UNHCR publishes <i>Setting up and development of an environmental database for refugee programmes : Phase 1, Africa : 1st results, February-July 1994</i>¹³³ • First comprehensive GIS-GPS review of possible use of these technologies in the humanitarian sector¹³⁴
	ReliefWeb: concept for ReliefWeb is drawn on the back of a New York restaurant place mat, by the founder of RwandaNet, over breakfast with DHA staff¹³⁵ DHA launches HCWEB (Humanitarian Crisis Web), leveraging UNIENET, as a gopher site on the Internet while waiting on the ReliefWeb project.¹³⁶ Contains: • General country information, such as maps and reports which cover donor countries, search and rescue teams, emergency response offices, emergency stockpiles, human rights reports, early-warning issues, natural disaster involvement reports, summaries of requirements to contributors, and other political, military, economic and disaster related information • URL: http://www.unicc.org/relief¹³⁷ DHA defines the <i>Principles of Data Collection</i> that will be used by Reliefweb: Timely, Trustly, and Verifiable information¹³⁸ • Verifiability required 3 different sources • Focus was on distribution of reports and graphic products. No inhouse data synthesis, analysis or products¹³⁹ DHA Angola (aka UN UCHA - Unidade de Coordenacao de Assuntos Humanitarios) has a Database Unit which includes Programmers and Registration Officers.¹⁴⁰ They work closely with UNAVEM (United Nations Verification Mission)¹⁴¹ • Many are contracted by DPKO, but working for DHA • Demobilizing soldiers¹⁴²: ◦ Deployed more than 100 computers with data collection systems in 25 quartering areas to record data about demobilized soldiers ◦ Data transmission via HF radios replaced data transmitted via floppy disk over aircrafts ◦ First time the UN uses digital photos → captured and merged into Cobol application running in PC 386 (100MB HD capacity and 8MB RAM)

¹³³ Setting up and development of an environmental database for refugee programmes : Phase 1, Africa : 1st results, February-July 1994 ([PDF](#))

¹³⁴ Written Respondent 06 received 9 March 2023

¹³⁵ Interviewee 08, March 2023. Daniel Zalek (RwandaNet) drew the diagram over breakfast with Sharon Rusu and Dennis King

¹³⁶ The involvement of the United Nations System in Providing And Coordinating Humanitarian Assistance - Erica-Irene Does - Joint Inspection Unit - 1995 ([PDF](#))

¹³⁷ Getting On-Line in Emergencies: A Guide and Directory to the Internet for Agencies involved - Relief and Rehabilitation Network - RRN - Network Paper 13 ([PDF](#))

¹³⁸ Interviewee 08, March 2023;

¹³⁹ Written Respondent 07 received on 11 May 2023

¹⁴⁰ Interviewee 19, April 2023

¹⁴¹ Written Respondent 08 received 11 April 2023

¹⁴² Written Respondent 08 received 11 April 2023

Year	Milestones
	○ Issued government recognized ID → merged digital photos and personal data collected in remote areas, printed in magnetic plastic ID cards with security 3D holograms stickers ● Tech included: PhotoCard, DeskJet, Dbase, Lotus123, Quattro Pro, MS Access. Simple queries were used for basic analysis ● GHOST (Geographic Humanitarian Operational System Tracker) also built by DHA Angola as a precursor to the 3W¹⁴³ ● Captured what may be the first humanitarian selfie while testing the PhotoCard system¹⁴⁴ The Integrated Regional Information Network (IRIN) opens its first office in Nairobi, Kenya, as an effort by the DHA to allow for cross-border inter-agency flows of information¹⁴⁵ ● Focus is journalism and narrative reporting and analysis.¹⁴⁶ It provides a regional focal point to receive and synthesize information, analyze and disseminate it to the community and, where necessary, fill information gaps ● Sets up its first email list¹⁴⁷ ● IRIN provides updates twice a day (1996) UN-HACO (Humanitarian Assistance Coordination Office) is established by DHA in Liberia¹⁴⁸ UNHCR publishes <i>UNHCR environment: development of a GIS system in UNHCR for environmental, emergency, logistic and planning purposes</i>¹⁴⁹ ● First comprehensive review of possible use of Remote Sensing (and GIS/GPS) in the humanitarian sector¹⁵⁰ First use of the internet and email in the Geneva HQ¹⁵¹ ● Red Cross starts putting together Appeals via email;
1996	DHA launches ReliefWeb, a humanitarian information portal¹⁵² ● Interesting notes: ○ Built with shareware/freeware downloaded from the Internet¹⁵³ ○ Built in 6 months¹⁵⁴ ○ Initial URL was http://www.unicc.org/relief ○ Before the ReliefWeb.int domain was launched, the team only had an IP address

¹⁴³ Written Respondent 08 received 11 April 2023

¹⁴⁴ Personal photo of Rogerio Mobilla Silva from September 1995 ([picture](#))

¹⁴⁵ The United Nations and Rwanda 1993-1996 - The Blue Book Series - Volume X ([PDF](#))

¹⁴⁶ Written Respondent 07 received on 11 May 2023

¹⁴⁷ Written Respondent 06 received 9 March 2023

¹⁴⁸ 1998 United Nations Consolidated Inter-Agency Appeal for Liberia accessed on 23 August 2023 ([PDF](#))

¹⁴⁹ UNHCR environment: development of a GIS system in UNHCR for environmental, emergency, logistic and planning purposes ([PDF](#))

¹⁵⁰ Written Respondent 06 received 9 March 2023;

¹⁵¹ Interviewee 11, March 2023

¹⁵² *ReliefWeb's Early Days* by Craig Duncan, 10 August 2021 ([PDF](#))

¹⁵³ Interviewee 08, March 2023

¹⁵⁴ Interviewee 20, May 2023

Year	Milestones
	- o ReliefNet was never a DHA domain as it was owned by a rock band called Relief - o With the help of the International Telecommunications Union (ITU), OCHA was able to secure the ReliefWeb.int domain - o On the day before launch, Daniel Zalik decides to use cookies (at the time “hot cookies”) to flip the website from English to French - o ReliefWeb was called to the Pentagon as they wanted to know what ReliefWeb was doing; Afterwards, a couple Pentagon staff sit with the ReliefWeb team for 3 weeks¹⁵⁵ The ReliefWeb Map Centre launches as a place where users can find “humanitarian community information maps” produced by ReliefWeb or collected from other organizations¹⁵⁶ • First maps are static reference maps created with DeLorme Mapping technology (DVD) and tracing things into PowerPoint¹⁵⁷ Response.Net launches a system where information is provided and then made available through the Internet, or through a locally-created E-mail system¹⁵⁸ Remote Sensing (Landsat and SPOT) used to detect and assess the environmental impacts of refugee camps in eastern Zaire (Goma)¹⁵⁹ Mobile phones (versus satellite or landlines) becoming more and more common in the sector¹⁶⁰ WGET (Working Group for Emergency Telecommunications) is established¹⁶¹ IRIN distribution of alerts by pager and fax gateway¹⁶² GISMO (Geographic Information System for the Myanmar Operation) is developed by UNHCR Myanmar¹⁶³
1997	Creation of the Sphere Project as well as the The Humanitarian Charter and Minimum Standards^{164 165} UN-HACO Liberia • Starts a Humanitarian Database Project which collects a lot of data

¹⁵⁵ Interviewee 08, March 2023

¹⁵⁶ Internet Archive - WayBackMachine, capture of ReliefWeb’s *About the Map Centre* page from 02 February 1997 ([PDF](#))

¹⁵⁷ Interviewee 21, March 2023

¹⁵⁸ Relief and Rehabilitation Network - Number 5 - Number 5, June 1996 ([PDF](#))

¹⁵⁹ Written Respondent 06 received 9 March 2023;

¹⁶⁰ Interviewee 11, March 2023

¹⁶¹ About - WGET ICT Humanitarian Innovation Forum 2015 ([PDF](#))

¹⁶² Written Respondent 06 received 9 March 2023

¹⁶³ Application of Technology in UNHCR Myanmar, Craig Williams, April 1996 ([PDF](#))

¹⁶⁴ The Sphere Handbook: Humanitarian Charter and Minimum Standards in Humanitarian Response - 2018 edition, 20 November 2018 ([PDF](#))

¹⁶⁵ Interviewee 18, May 2023

Year	Milestones
	○ Part of it holds 3W-like data and serves the same coordination purpose^{166 167} ○ Includes first documented Assessment database¹⁶⁸ ● Develops simple thematic mapping to capture cross organizational knowledge of field conditions (Joint Risk Mapping Project). Uses MS Access and MapInfo¹⁶⁹ ● Information played a significant role in the functions from humanitarian coordination to DDR¹⁷⁰ MADGIC (Multi Agency Distributed Geographic Information Collection) - an early donor led effort to track who-is-doing-what-where type information and to collect field data - is piloted in Liberia. Laminated cards are given out with GPS training - one side has details to collect structural information and the other is for programmatic data. Not one set of coordinates come back¹⁷¹ Sierra Leone information system, funded by the World Bank and run by Volunteers in Technical Assistance (VITO), is established as an Intranet to share information between the Government and the Humanitarian Sector¹⁷² FEWER (Forum on Early Warning and Early Response) - an early warning solution - is created in response of the Rwandan genocide and put in place through a consortium of UN Agencies and NGOs¹⁷³ HEWS (Humanitarian Early Warning System) is established by DHA¹⁷⁴ Participatory mapping: FAO uses aerial photos to conduct participatory mapping with communities¹⁷⁵ ● Watershed-related with the aim to help manage shocks (e.g. floods, droughts, etc.) ● Aerial photos are hung up and left with markers for locals to 'mark-up' the maps FAO Afghanistan takes over Development Alternatives Inc. which was founded in 1994 for projects on mapping and data collection¹⁷⁶ ● Renamed as Project Management Information System (ProMIS). Continues to update gazetteer, mapping and program data¹⁷⁷ ● The Afghan staff and project become the foundation for the UN Afghanistan Information Management System (AIMS) in 2002

¹⁶⁶ Interviewee 15, May 2023

¹⁶⁷ Liberia Humanitarian Situation Report No.75, 16 June 1997 ([PDF](#))

¹⁶⁸ Written Respondent 07 received on on 11 May 2023

¹⁶⁹ Written Respondent 07 received on on 11 May 2023

¹⁷⁰ Written Respondent 07 received on on 03 August 2023; UNHACO Liberia final reports - 1998 ([PDF](#))

¹⁷¹ Interviewee 04, March 2023; [MADGIC card PDF](#)

¹⁷² Interviewee 21, March 2023

¹⁷³ Interviewee 08, March 2023

¹⁷⁴ Written Respondent 02 received 24 March 2023; The Yearbook of the United Nations, 1997 ([PDF](#))

¹⁷⁵ Interviewee 22, March 2023

¹⁷⁶ Written Respondent 07 received on on 11 May 2023

¹⁷⁷ ProMIS Indicator Consultant Report - Afghanistan, 20 October 2000 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	AIMS is longest running information center, transitioning to national project and then an independent NGO before ending in 2017
1998	DHA becomes OCHA¹⁷⁸ 3 co-functions: coordination for the humanitarian emergency response, policy development, advocacy on humanitarian issues - Regular budget staff positions are reduced from 360 to 137 (62%).¹⁷⁹ Other positions are moved to “<i>projects</i>” which are funded through extra-budgetary financing.¹⁸⁰ Organization actually grows OCHA starts collaborating with the Global Disaster Information Network (GDIN)¹⁸¹ Creation of the Geographic Information Support Team (GIST)^{182 183184} - First inter-agency IM mechanism (focused on GIS) - Includes entities such as DPKO, FAO, World Bank, UNDP, WFP, WHO, UNHCR, UNICEF, OCHA, VVAF, OFDA, ECHO/JRC, and ITOS¹⁸⁵ - First note taker uses a Palm Pilot with an external keyboard¹⁸⁶ - Initially established as an informal collaboration by people with interest in GIS and new technology¹⁸⁷ GIST Repository setup by ITOS¹⁸⁸ - Share whatever data responders have when a new emergency hit - FTP-based - Concept inspired future COD-Repository and Humanitarian Data Exchange - USAID /OFDA funded and based at the University of Georgia¹⁸⁹ Aerial imagery, from hang gliders, is provided by the French Overseas Research Institute (ORSTOM) to enable UNHCR to map the Dadaab refugee camp and attach socio economic data for each households^{190 191} Tampere Convention on the Provision of Telecommunication Resources for Disaster Mitigation and Relief Operations (entered into force in 2005)¹⁹² Humanitarian Response Planning map - like a dashboard - is created with landsat data. Cutting edge & expensive at the time¹⁹³

¹⁷⁸ History of OCHA, unocha.org ([PDF](#))

¹⁷⁹ DHA renamed Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, UN DPI Bulletin, 26 January 1998 ([PDF](#))

¹⁸⁰ Interviewee 10, March 2023

¹⁸¹ Conclusions of Meeting of International Disaster Experts in Washington DC 16-17 July 1998 ([PDF](#))

¹⁸² OCHA in 2001 Activities And Extra Budgetary Funding Requirements, OCHA, 2001 ([PDF](#))

¹⁸³ Interviewee 23, April 2023

¹⁸⁴ GIST Terms of Reference - TOR - 2000 ([PDF](#))

¹⁸⁵ GIST Presentation - About - 2003 ([PDF](#))

¹⁸⁶ Interviewee 24, June 2023

¹⁸⁷ Interviewee 20, May 2023

¹⁸⁸ Interviewee 23, April 2023

¹⁸⁹ Written Respondent 07 received on 11 May 2023

¹⁹⁰ Interviewee 18, 02 May 2023

¹⁹¹ Environment, cartography, demography and geographical information system in the refugee camps - Dadaab, Kakuma - Kenya - Final Report - October 1999 ([PDF](#))

¹⁹² Tampere Convention on the Provision of Telecommunication Resources for Disaster Mitigation and Relief Operations, Tampere, 18 June 1998 ([PDF](#))

¹⁹³ Interviewee 04, March 2023; Humanitarian Response Planning Map - Kosovo 1998 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	It provides a common reference map for all parties and digital data is shared with all interested and capable humanitarian organizations. This model is repeated for Kosovo in 1999, giving the HCIC the ability to focus on humanitarian content rather than basemap creation¹⁹⁴
1999	Humanitarian Community Information Center (HCIC) is established in Kosovo based on experience from Rwanda¹⁹⁵ "The establishment of a HCIC to assist UN-led repatriation support efforts was a major break through in an evolving information-sharing regime"¹⁹⁶ 3 months in Macedonia before everyone returned provides a unique opportunity to coordinate, collaborate and then introduce innovation practices into the HCIC - Operates with an 'open data' principle; Any data they have is freely shared - quite counter to culture at the time and even some UN Agencies tried to refuse to share (as they wanted to hold their own data) - First time that the 3W is called <i>the</i> 3W¹⁹⁷ - First Humanitarian Information Centre website is hosted on ReliefWeb at http://www.reliefweb.int/hcic¹⁹⁸ - Creation of P-codes¹⁹⁹ - unique identifier that is apolitical and unambiguous (started from data for a map of Kosovo) → later becomes the basis for national electoral districts. Many colorful, p-code powered maps are created²⁰⁰ - HCIC Kosovo Atlas²⁰¹ - HCIC Kosovo Encyclopedia²⁰² - HCIC Map Catalogue is a MS Word file with hyperlinks to map files²⁰³ - GIS Working group is established - The US Govt flies a U2 spy plane to collect imagery for the humanitarian community. Classified materials so there is a dedicated container with US staff controlling access - German government provides drone imagery²⁰⁴ - Rapid Village Assessment (RVA) collects consistent data and is integrated into an Excel/GIS system used for monitoring and decision making²⁰⁵ - Provides an Internet Cafe to the humanitarian community²⁰⁶

¹⁹⁴ Written Respondent 10 received 28 August 2023

¹⁹⁵ Interviewee 21, March 2023

¹⁹⁶ Kosovo Brief: Information Management Offers a New Opportunity for Cooperation Between Civilian and Military by Michael Dziedzic and William Wood, 2000 ([PDF](#))

¹⁹⁷ 3W Database discussion paper prepared for HCIC in Kosovo by OCHA ([PDF](#)); Annex A from ProMIS Indicator Consultant Report - Afghanistan, 20 October 2000 ([PDF](#))

¹⁹⁸ HCIC Website on the Way Back Machine - Feb 2000 capture ([PDF](#))

¹⁹⁹ P-codes page on HCIC Website on Way Back Machine - Feb 2000 capture ([PDF](#))

²⁰⁰ Written Respondent 06 received 9 March 2023; Example PCode maps from HCIC ([ZIP](#))

²⁰¹ Written Respondent 11 received 30 March 2023

²⁰² Written Respondent 11 received 30 March 2023

²⁰³ Written Respondent 11 received 30 March 2023 | HCIC Map Catalogue ([PDF](#))

²⁰⁴ Interviewee 25, April 2023

²⁰⁵ Rapid Village Assessment - Kosovo ([PDF](#))

²⁰⁶ Interviewee 24, June 2023

Year	Milestones
	• USAID/OFDA funds technical assistance that lays out concepts and roadmap for future HIC development²⁰⁷ Virtual OSOCC (On-Site Operations Coordination Centre) is launched as a prototype. Officially launched in 2001²⁰⁸ Launch of <i>ReliefWeb via Email</i> for people that do not have web access²⁰⁹ All material from UNDRO (e.g. SitReps) on UNINET is digitized and uploaded on ReliefWeb for preservation²¹⁰ UN mounts digital cameras under the wings of UN aircrafts (without electricity in the cables so as not to create fires). A methodology of in-flight image acquisition, automatic correction of lens distortions, brightness correction, population data extrapolation is developed and used²¹¹ USAID-OFD receives IKONOS imagery of the Venezuela floods - first operational use of commercial, high resolution imagery for humanitarian purposes.²¹² (1m resolution vs SPOT's 10 m resolution) Y2K bug: focus of many technical people shifted to adjust software in anticipation of Y2K bug and possible systems' failure²¹³
2000	Launch of International Charter "<i>Space and Major Disasters</i>"²¹⁴ (aka Disaster Charter) UN-Emergencies Unit for Ethiopia (UN-EUE) is now managed by OCHA. Previously known as UNDP's Emergencies Unit for Ethiopia (EUE)²¹⁵ • Specific instructions from OCHA HQ to not call it an HIC²¹⁶ Information Coordination Centre setup in Eritrea²¹⁷ • Resourced by OCHA/UNDAC, UNICEF, ERREC, NCA & EDF²¹⁸ • Co-led by the Eritrean government who had veto power over publication of maps. They do not approve a single map in 2 years as they do not agree with the border. Result: Maps are marked as '<i>Draft</i>' and shared with every agency in the country '<i>For Comment</i>'²¹⁹ SLIS (Sierra Leone Information System) setup²²⁰

²⁰⁷ Written Respondent 07 received on 11 May 2023

²⁰⁸ Technology and information sharing in disasters, Benedikte Bjerger, Nathan Clark, Peter Fisker, Emmanuel Raju, 1 September 2016 ([PDF](#))

²⁰⁹ Interviewee 14, March 2023

²¹⁰ Interviewee 14, 10 March 2023

²¹¹ Tesi in GIS e Remote Sensing In Paesi in Via Di Sviluppo (Dottorato Di Ricerca In Tecnologie Energetiche E Ambientali Per Lo Sviluppo), Giorgio Sartori, 25 May 2000 ([PDF](#))

²¹² Written Respondent 10 received 28 August 2023

²¹³ Interviewee 19, May 2023

²¹⁴ International Charter Space and Major Disasters, Office for Outer Space Affairs UN-SPIDER Knowledge Portal ([PDF](#))

²¹⁵ About UN-EUE on the WayBackMachine ([PDF](#))

²¹⁶ Interviewee 26, April 2023

²¹⁷ Written Respondent 12 received 3 June 2023

²¹⁸ Eritrea: ICC Weekly Update for 10 Jun 2000 ([PDF](#)) | Ongoing Humanitarian Information Activities and Issues - Global - August 2001 ([PDF](#))

²¹⁹ Written Respondent 01 received 28 August 2023

²²⁰ OCHA in 2002 Activities and Extrabudgetary Funding Requirements ([PDF](#)) | Ongoing Humanitarian Information Activities and Issues - Global - August 2001 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	First Joint Mission Analysis Cell (JMAC) setup in Sierra Leone²²¹ • Concept requires the inclusion of a humanitarian presence • JMAC concept later becomes the SIOC (Security Information Operational Cell)²²² UNGIWG (United Nations Geographic Information Working Group) is established²²³ Strong Angel consortium holds its first international civ-mil disaster response event. Goals include working on improved information flow and transboundary cooperation²²⁴
2001	DEPHA (Data Exchange Platform for the Horn of Africa) is created as an effort to set up regional GIS capacity²²⁵ • It is first referred to as the HAIC (Humanitarian Assistance Information Centre) later becoming the "Data Warehouse"²²⁶ and then DEPHA²²⁷ • Initially hosted with the UNOPS project for Somalia under UNDP. It later moves to UNEP Nairobi and then UNDP Kenya²²⁸ • Data is made available publicly on FTP²²⁹ • HAIC website starts on unsomalia.org²³⁰; DEPHA eventually sets up on hornofafricadata.org²³¹ • Sudan: DEPHA team digitizes British Survey maps in partnership with the government²³² • Some GIS data <i>"fell off the back of a truck"</i> CHIN (Common Humanitarian Information Network for the Horn of Africa) is set up by OCHA in Ethiopia²³³ • Objective: To improve the quality and timeliness of humanitarian information and to promote information sharing practices in the HOA Launch of UNOSAT²³⁴ Creation of SAHIMS (Southern Africa Humanitarian Information Management Network)²³⁵ IRIN Radio is introduced to provide individuals and communities with unbiased information on issues and events²³⁶

²²¹ Interviewee 27, April 2023

²²² Interviewee 28, May 2023

²²³ United Nations Geographic Information Working Group - about UNGIWG-9, Way Back Machine 3 July 2023 capture ([PDF](#))

²²⁴ Written Respondent 14 received 23 March 2023

²²⁵ Interviewee 22, March 2023

²²⁶ Note for the File - Continuation of the Data and Information Teams Activities by Ben Watkins - 15-May-2001 ([PDF](#))

²²⁷ Ongoing Humanitarian Information Activities and Issues - Global - August 2001 ([PDF](#))

²²⁸ Interviewee 29, April 2023

²²⁹ Interviewee 29, April 2023

²³⁰ WayBackMachine capture ([PDF](#))

²³¹ HAIC - Meeting summary of 15 May 2001 ([PDF](#)); WayBackMachine capture ([PDF](#))

²³² Interviewee 22, March 2023

²³³ Humanitarian Information, resource Centers in Africa and Related Activities ([PDF](#))

²³⁴ UNOSAT: 20 Years Of Operations Leading To The United Nations Satellite Centre ([PDF](#))

²³⁵ Southern Africa: Humanitarian data management system launched, 21 October 2002 ([PDF](#))

²³⁶ IRIN Booklet - Giving Voice to the Voiceless ([PDF](#)); IRIN outreach radio project ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	OCHA hires a couple people to walk the perimeter of the Goma Volcano lava flow, with GPS units, so that it could then be mapped²³⁷ The Field Information Services (FIS) unit is created in OCHA New York as its first dedicated unit for leading and supporting field-focused information management²³⁸ - Hiring source of future HIC staff includes several people from the UN's Department of PeaceKeeping (DPKO) as they have GIS skills²³⁹ OCHA proposes to setup an Information Management Section in Geneva that would include internal activities (e.g. FTS management) and external services (e.g. Virtual OSOCC and Operational Coordination Centre)²⁴⁰ OCHA and UNICEF propose SHARE (Structured Humanitarian Assistance Reporting Approach)²⁴¹ - Simple, common standards in collecting and reporting humanitarian-related information based on things like data of information, source of information, and location (p-code) ITOS begins a pilot project that will become the UN GIS data clearinghouse²⁴² SALB (Second Administrative Level Boundaries) project started^{243 244} - It is envisioned as WHO's contribution to UNGIWG - Saw so many different admin boundaries being used across the UN - Estimates that it will take ~6 months to complete²⁴⁵ - Moves to the UN Cartographic Section in 2011²⁴⁶ where it was parked until 2018 before restarting²⁴⁷ iMMAP is created as a unit of the Vietnam Veterans of America Foundation (VVAf)²⁴⁸
2002	Symposium on Best Practices in Humanitarian Information Management and Exchange²⁴⁹ ReliefWeb introduces Humanitarian Vacancies (aka Jobs)²⁵⁰ DFID hosts design, planning and development session for HIC training in London, UK²⁵¹

²³⁷ Interviewee 21, March 2023; Product: DR Congo: Goma Town Centre Lava Map, 27 Jan 2002 ([PDF](#))

²³⁸ OCHA in 2001 Activities And Extra Budgetary Funding Requirements, OCHA, 2001 ([PDF](#))

²³⁹ Interviewee 23, April 2023

²⁴⁰ Memo from OCHA Geneva to OCHA New titled *Information Management Section* on 11 April 2001 ([PDF](#)); Written Respondent 13 received 17 March 2023

²⁴¹ Structured Humanitarian Assistance Reporting - SHARE - GIST-Joint-Presentation - 8 Feb 2001 ([PDF](#))

²⁴² Written Respondent 15 received 20 April 2023

²⁴³ Written Respondent 15 received 23 August 2023

²⁴⁴ SALB Methodology ([PDF](#))

²⁴⁵ Interviewee 02, August 2023

²⁴⁶ SALB Methodology ([PDF](#))

²⁴⁷ Interview with Steeve Ebener on 30 August 2023

²⁴⁸ Our History - iMMAP ([PDF](#))

²⁴⁹ Symposium on Best Practices in Humanitarian Information Exchange, 1 February 2002 ([PDF](#))

²⁵⁰ Reliefweb capture on Way Back Machine from 28 May 2002 - First Jobs ([PDF](#))

²⁵¹ Written Respondent 07 received on 11 May 2023

Year	Milestones
	Closure Mapping starts in oPt / Israel²⁵² - Initial maps are hand drawn and/or created in Photoshop - Maps showing Israeli checkpoints and blockades that stop Palestinians from accessing services, jobs, etc.²⁵³ - Although initially quite annoyed, the Israeli authorities begin using OCHA products and data as <i>their</i> source-of-truth AIMS (Afghanistan Information Management Service) - a HIC-like centre - was setup²⁵⁴ - GIS specialists, and their data, sourced from the UNDP/FAO project called PROMIS (which had launched in 1997)²⁵⁵ - Develop a p-code system, run Maps on Demand, source and support imagery maps, leverage 1979 series Soviet 1:50,000 map series²⁵⁶ - Develop text editing to produce first cartographic products with Dar and Pashtun characters²⁵⁷ MapAction is created, but initially named Aid for Aid²⁵⁸ - Is setup as a result of a mapping project in the Kosovo in December 1999²⁵⁹ - Renamed to MapAction in 2004²⁶⁰ - Vodafone comes in early to support - including financial means to hire the first manager. Really helped kickoff MapAction²⁶¹ UNHCR maps the Kakuma camp by taping a GPS device to the front of a motorbike and driving around²⁶² First biometrics capture in the sector by UNHCR²⁶³ - Used to manage the issuance of repatriation grants in Pakistan for refugee returnees about to travel from Pakistan back to Afghanistan OCHA staff member scuba dives in Lake Goma every morning during the 2002 EQ response to look for '<i>disoriented fish</i>' that might indicate escaping methane²⁶⁴ The UN Department of Peacekeeping Operations (DPKO) launches their first Geo-cell in the Ethiopia/Eritrea operation. Concept expands to another 5 operations within a year signaling that the UN family needed to take GIS seriously²⁶⁵
2003	HIC Iraq

²⁵² Interviewee 30, March 2023

²⁵³ Interviewee 31, March 2023

²⁵⁴ Afghanistan: Information management to play key role in aid work ([PDF](#))

²⁵⁵ Written Respondent 17 received 10 May 2023

²⁵⁶ Written Respondent 07 received on 11 May 2023

²⁵⁷ Written Respondent 07 received on 11 May 2023

²⁵⁸ MapAction - About us - History ([PDF](#))

²⁵⁹ Rupert Douglas-Bate: Chairman and Founder ([PDF](#)); Interviewee 32, May 2023

²⁶⁰ Written Respondent 18 received 17 May 2023; Note: Aid for Aid was incorporated in 1999, but had no activity until 2002

²⁶¹ Interviewee 32, May 2023

²⁶² Interviewee 22, March 2023

²⁶³ Afghan "recyclers" under scrutiny of new technology 03 October 2002 ([PDF](#)); and UNHCR's 20 Years of Biometrics slide ([PDF](#))

²⁶⁴ Written Respondent 01 received 27 August 2023

²⁶⁵ Interviewee 33, March 2023

Year	Milestones
	• First public HIC website URL is: <i>agoodplacetostart.org</i>.²⁶⁶ The staff even have T-shirts with the phrase on them²⁶⁷. ◦ A private discussion group on Mayetic Village exists beforehand²⁶⁸ • HIC is equipped with the first deployment of the DFID rapid deployment package → part of the <i>HIC-in-a-box</i> concept²⁶⁹; • OCHA deploys HIC teams to multiple locations including Basra, Baghdad, Mosul, Larnaca and Amman²⁷⁰ • The HIC in Bagdad is destroyed as part of the Canal Hotel bombing counting several victims among the UN staff²⁷¹ • Humanitarian Operation Center (US Govt) uses Groove to share information and data with external partners including the HIC²⁷² • First documented online Assessment database (i.e. Survey of Survey)²⁷³ • Basra: Hard drives are stored in the fridge to extend their life²⁷⁴ <i>Music/Movies-for-Data</i> was initiated by HIC Basra²⁷⁵ • Visitors could take a copy of the music/movies from a hard drive if they provided a copy of the data to the HIC Basra HIC Liberia is established²⁷⁶ • Leads the national remapping effort, meeting with tribal leaders in each state, to rewrite the country's placenames city/town/settlement, health centers, road status, and generally mapping places²⁷⁷. = ◦ Maps they had beforehand were old American/British maps which had been saved by an individual Liberian who took them from the government office (during the war) to hide them at home for safe keeping²⁷⁸. ◦ Political will is the driver to get the work done as an election is upcoming - results in donor funding being available²⁷⁹. HDRC (Humanitarian Development Resource Centre) is established in DPR Korea (aka North Korea)²⁸⁰ Due to copyright and file size limitations on sharing imagery, OFDA traces a detailed road network from Geneina Darfur, Sudan, posts the data on the GIST repository where an OCHA cartographer promptly discovers it and converts it to a useful map²⁸¹

²⁶⁶ Interviewee 22, March 2023; HIC Iraq website on Wayback Machine ([PDF](#))

²⁶⁷ Pictures of A Good Place to Start T-shirts ([PDF](#))

²⁶⁸ Humanitarian Information Capacity - Middle East (aka HIC Iraq) proposal 2002; Service no longer online;

²⁶⁹ Humanitarian Information Capacity - Middle East (aka HIC Iraq) proposal 2002; Service no longer online;

²⁷⁰ Written Respondent 19 received 18 August 2023

²⁷¹ United Nations In Memoriam: Baghdad, 19 August 2003 ([PDF](#))

²⁷² Interviewee 34, March 2023

²⁷³ HIC Website - Assessments; WayBackMachine ([PDF](#))

²⁷⁴ Interviewee 15, May 2023

²⁷⁵ Interviewee 35, May 2023

²⁷⁶ Janet O'Callaghan presentation at ESRI conference, 2 May 2023 ([PDF](#))

²⁷⁷ Written Respondent 19 received 18 August 2023

²⁷⁸ Interviewee 36, August 2023

²⁷⁹ Interviewee 36, August 2023

²⁸⁰ Capture of HDRC website capture on Way Back Machine ([PDF](#)); Personal experience of author

²⁸¹ Written Respondent 10 received 28 August 2023

Year	Milestones
	• Demonstrates the utility of passive collaboration made possible through portals and standards ReliefWeb starts making its own maps for emergencies²⁸² • With every new GLIDE number, ReliefWeb makes a map GOS (Geographic Operational System) is launched by OCHA Angola²⁸³ • Includes mapping built on top of Microsoft Access without any GIS tools. Produces such things as the Surface Routes for Humanitarian Operations - January 2003²⁸⁴ Bam Earthquake • Video-conference first used by the field - the UNDAC Team Leader briefs the HQ-based donors about the situation²⁸⁵ • Without a map, the UNDAC team borrow a tourist map & draw a large scale version to hang on the wall²⁸⁶ WHO proposes the creation of the IASC Task Force on Information Management²⁸⁷ UNGIWG recommends SALB coding scheme as a standard across agencies²⁸⁸ (but no consistent adoption across agencies ever happens as there was no entity to enforce it²⁸⁹) • UNGIWG encourages the submission of the SALB scheme to ISO/TC211 for adoption as an international standard²⁹⁰ GISCorps is founded²⁹¹ World Summit on the Information Society²⁹² • Heads of States and Governments approve the Geneva Declaration of Principles²⁹³ and the Geneva Plan of Action²⁹⁴ for the Information Society • First ever global platform to bring together the international community, including Heads of State and Government, Executive Heads of United Nations agencies, national delegates and leaders from non-governmental organizations (NGOs), industry leaders, media representatives and civil society

²⁸² Interviewee 23, April 2023

²⁸³ Interviewee 37, May 2023; Interviewee 19, April 2023

²⁸⁴ Pre-GIS, hand-drawn map of Surface Routes for Humanitarian Operations - January 2003 ([PDF](#))

²⁸⁵ Interviewee 10, March 2023

²⁸⁶ Interviewee 38, May 2023; [PDF picture of map](#)

²⁸⁷ Interviewee 13, March 2023

²⁸⁸ Report on the fourth plenary meeting of the UNGIWG - 22-24 October 2003 accessed 30 August ([PDF](#))

²⁸⁹ Interviewee 02, August 2023

²⁹⁰ Report on the fourth plenary meeting of the UNGIWG - 22-24 October 2003 accessed 30 August ([PDF](#))

²⁹¹ Our History - GISCorps ([PDF](#))

²⁹² ICT4Peace email on 20 December 2023 titled "20th Anniversary of the World Summit on the Information Society (WSIS) in Geneva" ([PDF](#)); World Summit on the Information Society - First Phase - Geneva ([PDF](#))

²⁹³ Declaration of Principles - World summit on the Information Society - Geneva - December 2003 ([PDF](#))

²⁹⁴ Plan of Action - World summit on the Information Society - Geneva - December 2003 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
2004	OCHA USG / ERC gets a BlackBerry. Realization by management that information has just become more “<i>real time</i>”²⁹⁵
	HIC Darfur is established²⁹⁶ - Collecting data from so many sources, to create maps, results in an affectionate name of “<i>spaghetti data</i>” as it comes in randomly and takes significant time to clean & process. Sources range from digitizing Russian (Cyrillic) military topographic maps to individual handheld GPS data collected on site visits.²⁹⁷ - GPS devices have such low memory that data is downloaded and then the memory is cleared.²⁹⁸
	Integrated Food Security Phase Classification (IPC) launches initially for Somalia²⁹⁹
	Global Disaster Alert and Coordination System (GDACS) is setup as a cooperation framework between the United Nations and the European Commission³⁰⁰
	Displacement Tracking Matrix is created by Global Camp Coordination and Camp Management group³⁰¹
	Creation of Sahana after the Tsunami in Sri Lanka³⁰²
	GLIDE (GLobal IDentifier Number) is launched by the Asian Disaster Reduction Center (ADRC), UNOCHA, and other partners³⁰³
	First Humanitarian Information Management training held in UK near Redding³⁰⁴
	HIC Toolbox created³⁰⁵
	ISCRAM (Information Systems for Crisis Response and Management) is founded³⁰⁶ - Brings different sciences together to work on crisis & information - Aims to bring academia and practitioners together³⁰⁷ TRIPLEX exercise (September in Norway) - UNDAC invites MapAction to be their mapping arm of UNDAC

²⁹⁵ Interviewee 10, March 2023

²⁹⁶ Janet O’Callaghan presentation at ESRI conference, 2 May 2023 ([PDF](#))

²⁹⁷ Written Respondent 11 received 30 March 2023

²⁹⁸ Written Respondent 11 received 30 March 2023

²⁹⁹ Integrated Food Security Phase Classification (IPC) launched initially for Somalia, IPC, December 2012 ([PDF](#))

³⁰⁰ Global Disaster Alert and Coordination System - GDACS ([PDF](#))

³⁰¹ Displacement Tracking Matrix - About ([PDF](#))

³⁰² Sahana foundation - History ([PDF](#)); “Sahana” means “relief” in Sinhalese

³⁰³ GLobal IDentifier Number (GLIDE) - About GLIDE ([PDF](#))

³⁰⁴ Interviewee 12, March 2023

³⁰⁵ HIC Toolbox V1 from 2004

³⁰⁶ About ISCRAM ([PDF](#))

³⁰⁷ Interviewee 39, May 2023

Year	Milestones
	- At the end of the exercise, MapAction is specifically thanked noting that UNDAC “could now see the value of mapping in emergency response”³⁰⁸ MapAction attends their first UNDAC induction course and provides GIS/GPS training in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia³⁰⁹ ReliefWeb receives the UN 21 award (now Secretary General awards)³¹⁰ OSM (Open Street Map) is founded³¹¹ First in depth study on the <i>Value of Information</i> focused on Rapid Humanitarian Assessments and Rationality in Iraq³¹² - Commissioned by VVAF
2005	The Humanitarian Reform Agenda launches after the 2004 Indian Ocean Tsunami. It introduces: - the cluster approach including clear leadership and accountability - a strengthened Humanitarian Coordinators’ role - strengthened Humanitarian Financing including an expanded CERF Four HICs setup:³¹³ - Sri Lanka - Sumatra - Niger - Pakistan 2004 Indian Ocean Tsunami: - The Cluster Approach is introduced as part of the Humanitarian Reform Agenda (after the Indian Ocean tsunami and Sudan response)³¹⁴ - ReliefWeb starts to cover natural disasters as per the directive of the USG (Jan Egeland). Previously they only covered man-made disasters³¹⁵ - Kofi Annan requests maps every day for UN noon briefings; Maps became real “tools”³¹⁶. When visiting the disaster zone, Kofi visited the MapAction office and requested all the maps available³¹⁷ - Colin Powell, after looking at his MapAction packet of briefing maps, stated that he had “never been so well briefed on a disaster”³¹⁸

³⁰⁸ Interviewee 40, April 2023

³⁰⁹ Interviewee 41, May 2023

³¹⁰ *ReliefWeb's Early Days* by Craig Duncan, 10 August 2021 ([PDF](#))

³¹¹ History of OpenStreetMap ([PDF](#))

³¹² Rapid humanitarian assessments and rationality: a value-of-information study from Iraq, 2003-04 by Aldo Benini and Charles Conley ([PDF](#))

³¹³ Janet O'Callaghan presentation at ESRI conference, 2 May 2023 ([PDF](#))

³¹⁴ Cluster Coordination topic on ReliefWeb ([PDF](#))

³¹⁵ Interviewee 11, March 2023

³¹⁶ Interviewee 11, March 2023

³¹⁷ A Short History of MapAction: 1994 to 2010 with a focus on the early years by Rupert Douglas-Bate 2011; ([PDF](#))

³¹⁸ A Short History of MapAction: 1994 to 2010 with a focus on the early years by Rupert Douglas-Bate 2011; ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	• Recognition that the HIC model is not scalable to service the entire humanitarian community. Need to build up IM capacity outside the HICs³¹⁹ • Recognition in the sector that communication had shifted from HF Radio to cellular³²⁰ • Early recognition that cell phones had enough penetration to switch from HF radio. During a 40 minute call, one responder received more than 50 SMS prompting the discussion.³²¹ HIC Sumatra produces maps of the consolidation of mass graves in and around Banda Aceh (at the request of a Norwegian NGO)³²² Kashmir (Pakistan) earthquake • First in-country/local IM Working Group meeting with <u>cluster</u> IM focal points³²³ • HIC folder structure and file naming convention, including GIS data, are introduced into the HIC by MapAction³²⁴ and ReliefWeb³²⁵. This structure was adopted by the UNJLC in-country³²⁶. The structure is later adopted across OCHA • Road maps created by UNJLC are used by Pakistani military who marked them as “Top Secret”³²⁷ ◦ First time for GPS-based road assessments (cars and mountain bikes took GPS devices and recorded way points of changes in the road situation or type)³²⁸ • HIC scans a massive (military) wall map with an A4 printer over one night (in 54 pieces). Digitized and sent to Islamabad on a USB key for printing. Used for planning work³²⁹ • “Subway” map of relief zones was created by iMMAP in support to UNJLC³³⁰ HIC Sri Lanka • First OCHA Map templates are developed by the HIC and and HQ deployee³³¹ HIC-Lite is deployed to Niger³³² • Attempted to run a HIC with a small team and only hand-carried equipment

³¹⁹ Interviewee 22, March 2023

³²⁰ Interviewee 34, March 2023

³²¹ Written Respondent 14 received 30 March 2023; Phone call by Nigel Snoad

³²² Written Respondent 20 received 7 June 2023

³²³ Cluster Coordination topic on ReliefWeb ([PDF](#))

³²⁴ Interviewee 42, May 2023

³²⁵ Interviewee 43, May 2023; ReliefWeb had just developed their own standard

³²⁶ Written Respondent 21 received 14 March 2023

³²⁷ Interviewee 44, March 2023; Written Respondent 07 received 11 May 2023

³²⁸ Interviewee 44, September 2023

³²⁹ Interviewee 45, June 2023; Interviewee 46, July 2023

³³⁰ Written Respondent 07 received on 11 May 2023 | [Subway Map PDF](#)

³³¹ Interviewee 46, July 2023

³³² Interviewee 47, April 2023

Year	Milestones
	The first Cluster Monitoring System is created by OCHA Uganda as an inter-agency initiative in collaboration with UNICEF, UNDP and IOM. • A data entry application incorporating GIS as output, monitoring the assistance and services delivered in more than 160 IDP camps OCHA holds its first global training for Information Management Officers Adobe Illustrator is first used in OCHA by ReliefWeb's Map Centre³³³ • Begins the shift inside OCHA from solely GIS-mapping to infographics. First international humanitarian organization to make this shift³³⁴ OCHA's Field Guidelines Version 1.0 are released on CD³³⁵ • Various templates to help OCHA office setup (IM, Admin, Reporting, etc) Hot Spot Matrix design is first launched in OCHA DRC³³⁶ • Combines data and human analysis to assign scores by location OCHA releases the Needs Analysis Framework (NAF) tool to try and improve the identification of multi-sector humanitarian needs³³⁷ FiDMS (Field Document Management System)³³⁸ and ODMS (OCHA Document Management System) are launched in Lotus Notes after about 3 months of development³³⁹ • Each OCHA office had their own FiDMS instance which replicated with HQ (both NY and Geneva) • HQ used ODMS HIC Sri Lanka receives the UN 21 award (now Secretary General awards) in the category "Field-based Projects"^{340 341} Tampere Convention comes into force³⁴² • Aims to reduce/waive regulatory barriers that impede the use of telecommunication resources for disasters Tunis Agreement: <i>Information and Communication Technology for Peace - The Role of ICT in Preventing, Responding to and Recovering from Conflict</i> • Heads of state recognize the importance of IT including in humanitarian action³⁴³

³³³ Poster - ReliefWeb's Mapping History as of 2007 ([PDF](#))

³³⁴ Interviewee 43, May 2023

³³⁵ Interviewee 26, April 2023; Written Respondent 22 received 18 April 2023

³³⁶ Interviewee 37, May 2023; Interviewee 19, April 2023

³³⁷ A Review of Needs Assessment Tools, Response Analysis Frameworks, and Targeting Guidance for Urban Humanitarian Response by Lili Mohiddin and Gabrielle Smith in 2016 ([PDF](#))

³³⁸ OCHA Annual Report 2005 ([PDF](#))

³³⁹ Personal experience of author

³⁴⁰ UN21 Awards 2005 ([PDF](#))

³⁴¹ Certificate of UN21 Award for the HIC Sri Lanka - picture ([PDF](#))

³⁴² Tampere Convention ([PDF](#))

³⁴³ Paragraph 36 in *Information and Communication Technology for Peace - The Role of ICT in Preventing, Responding to and Recovering from Conflict* by Daniel Stauffacher, William Drake, Paul Curron and Julia Steinberger ([PDF](#)); Interviewee 48, May 2023

Year	Milestones
	Google Earth is released putting geo into the hands of non-GIS specialists for the first time (in a major way) Increases the demand for GIS solutions as people better understand the value and power of geo tools/solutions³⁴⁴ People Finder Interchange Format (PFIF) is released and became the standard used by several humanitarian people finder/matching initiatives³⁴⁵ KoboToolbox is established. It is initially used by survey researchers working in challenging environments. In 2010 UNDP becomes the first international organization to adopt KoboToolbox. OCHA adopts it in 2013³⁴⁶
2006	OCHA, during an HQ mission to Kampala, drafts the first version of the scope for its future Information Management Units³⁴⁷ HIC Sri Lanka merges with the OCHA Sri Lanka office to become one of OCHA's first IMUs (Information Management Unit)³⁴⁸ OCHA launches a new web-based 3W which is used by all OCHA offices³⁴⁹ HIC Lebanon is setup³⁵⁰ - First Virtual HIC,³⁵¹ called vHIC, with support from multiple time zones providing 24/7 support.³⁵² Happens partly by accident as outbreak of violence keeps all but one HIC member outside of the country³⁵³ - P-codes really worked well in the response; People can not get into the country, but have time and data beforehand. Shared P-codes in XLS & responders use it in their organization³⁵⁴ - Screenshots of Google Earth are put into PPT so people could annotate freely³⁵⁵ ReliefWeb tests a daily Podcast of headline news³⁵⁶ HIC Toolbox is updated³⁵⁷ George Clooney uses HIC Darfur map while briefing the UN Security Council about the situation in Darfur³⁵⁸

³⁴⁴ Interviewee 40, April 2023; Note: Google purchased KeyHole in 2004.

³⁴⁵ A personal history of the effort to find the survivors of Hurricane Katrina, Kieran Lal, September 2005, Way Back Machine ([PDF](#))

³⁴⁶ KoboToolbox - About Us ([PDF](#))

³⁴⁷ Interviewee 19, April 2023

³⁴⁸ Interviewee 49, May 2023

³⁴⁹ Personal experience of author

³⁵⁰ Janet O'Callaghan presentation at ESRI conference, 2 May 2023 ([PDF](#))

³⁵¹ Interviewee 26, April 2023

³⁵² Interviewee 36, August 2023; Written Respondent received on 18 August 2023

³⁵³ Interviewee 47, April 2023

³⁵⁴ Interviewee 50, May 2023

³⁵⁵ Interviewee 15, May 2023

³⁵⁶ Poster: ReliefWeb 10 Years of Services to the Humanitarian Community ([PDF](#))

³⁵⁷ Interviewee 35, May 2023

³⁵⁸ Interviewee 47, April 2023; Photos: George Clooney At The U.N. ([PDF](#)) and Examining map with USG ([JPG](#))

Year	Milestones
	OCHA oPt, and other offices in the coming years, develop map symbology³⁵⁹ • Informed future OCHA Mapping Guidance and Humanitarian Icons One of the first known cases of remote humanitarian IM support in emergencies: UN's Joint Logistics Centre, in Kashmir, provides GIS data to the GIST who clean it up overnight³⁶⁰ Second HIC training in UK³⁶¹ OCHA's Regional Office for Asia and the Pacific (ROAP) creates the first version of a Focus Model³⁶² (precursor to the Global Focus Model and INFORM) OCHA ROAP outlines the benefit of data preparedness by comparing 150 days after the 2005 Pakistan EQ and 15 days after the 2006 Yogyakarta EQ³⁶³ ISCRAM holds their first summer school³⁶⁴ Wikimapia launches and is often used by HIC/OCHA GIS officers as a way to look up place names including alternative place names (but can not find on traditional sources)³⁶⁵ • Usage stops when Google started charging to use its maps/data in background
2007	Global Symposium +5 on Information for Humanitarian Action • Expands beyond technical IM to include topics such as reporting and communication³⁶⁶ OCHA's Information Management Review³⁶⁷ REDHUM is launched by OCHA in the Latin American and Caribbean region³⁶⁸ Initial Humanitarian Profile Maps created by OCHA³⁶⁹ • Shifts from general situational maps to more analytical • Combines situation report info, trends, different thematic data, etc. First Global Information Management Working Group Maps-On-Demand, powered by a GeoNetwork instance, is launched by OCHA³⁷⁰

³⁵⁹Interviewee 30, March 2023

³⁶⁰Written Respondent 21 received 14 March 2023

³⁶¹Interviewee 12, March 2023

³⁶²Interviewee 13, March 2023; Asia and the Pacific: 2016 Regional Focus Model ([PDF](#))

³⁶³Data Preparedness Initiative - OCHA ROAP ([PDF](#))

³⁶⁴Interviewee 39, May 2023

³⁶⁵Interviewee 50, May 2023

³⁶⁶Global Symposium +5 on Information for Humanitarian Action - Final Report, 2007 ([PDF](#))

³⁶⁷Information Management Review of OCHA, 2007([PDF](#))

³⁶⁸Regional organizations launch Redhum, the new humanitarian website for Latin America and the Caribbean, 2007 ([PDF](#))

³⁶⁹Interviewee 43, May 2023

³⁷⁰Capture of OCHA's GeoNetwork home page on Way Back Machine, 08 January 2007 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	• OCHA contributes to launch of GeoNetwork v2.1 in 2007³⁷¹ • The Maps-On-Demand project is offline by the end of 2008 <i>Beer-for-Data</i> starts in the Taj Guest House in Jalalabad, Afghanistan³⁷² MIMU (Myanmar Information Management Unit) is established³⁷³ • With absence of OCHA, MIMU is setup within the HC's office to support the IASC and the UN country team.³⁷⁴ The concept is considered for the Philippines, but not executed GBVIMS - the interagency standard for gender based violence monitoring - is launched³⁷⁵ UN Crisis Information Management Strategy established (led by UN CITO).³⁷⁶ Includes 4 pillars: Data architecture, Technology, Stakeholder management, and Capacity building UNGIWG-8 conference is hosted by OCHA's Regional Office for the Asia Pacific (ROAP) in Bangkok³⁷⁷
2008	Last Humanitarian Information Centre (HIC) deployment³⁷⁸ happens in response to Cyclone Nargis • Last full deployment of HIC equipment to support³⁷⁹ • Official request was to support the Myanmar Information Management Unit (MIMU)³⁸⁰ • Microsoft offers to build a new information exchange interface for emergencies (i.e. future OneResponse)^{381 382} First big coordinated assessments:³⁸³ • PONJA (Post Nargis Joint Assessment) in Myanmar • McRAM (Multi-cluster Rapid Assessment Mechanism) in Pakistan <i>IASC Operational Guidance on Responsibilities of Cluster/Sector Leads and OCHA in Information Management</i> is released³⁸⁴ Information Analysis Unit is launched in the Iraq operation³⁸⁵ Online Project System (OPS) is launched by OCHA to support the CAP

³⁷¹ GeoNetwork OpenSource: Geographic data sharing for everyone, presentation by Allison Fleming ([PDF](#))

³⁷² The Merry Pranksters Who Hacked the Afghan War, Brian Calvert, 1 July 2013 ([PDF](#))

³⁷³ About the MIMU ([PDF](#)); Revised TOR MIMU Consultant from Shawn Boeser ([PDF](#))

³⁷⁴ Written Respondent 19 received 18 August 2023

³⁷⁵ Written Respondent 23 received 13 March 2023

³⁷⁶ Strengthening Crisis Information Management, Daniel Stauffacher, 17 October 2011 ([PDF](#)); Interviewee 48, May 2023

³⁷⁷ Written Respondent 19 received 18 August 2023

³⁷⁸ HC OiC made a formal request for the HIC to come and support the MIMU: Interviewee 36, August 2023

³⁷⁹ Interviewee 22, March 2023

³⁸⁰ Interviewee 22, March 2023 Interviewee 36, August 2023

³⁸¹ Interviewee 47, April 2023

³⁸² OneResponse mockup from 2008 ([JPG](#))

³⁸³ Interviewee 51, April 2023

³⁸⁴ IASC Operational Guidance on Responsibilities of Cluster/Sector Leads and OCHA in Information Management; Accessed ([PDF](#))

³⁸⁵ Interviewee 45, June 2023

Year	Milestones
	(Consolidated Appeals Process)³⁸⁶ Mini-D (Mini Directory) is released by OCHA Sri Lanka • Small laminated cards on a key ring that include key information for responders. Variety of information including 3W of people, hotels, roads, embassies, etc.³⁸⁷ Launch of Ushahidi project using live collaborative mapping for Kenya post-election violence → first use of crowdsourcing³⁸⁸ Subsequently: - Haiti earthquake (2010) crowdsourcing and “real-time” data through use of “uncommon platforms” such as social media - Russia fires (2010) creation of a “help map” - Pakistan floods (2010) - Libya crisis (2011) IASC adopts the <i>Common Operation Datasets (CODs) and P-Codes</i>³⁸⁹ The first set of humanitarian icons are released³⁹⁰ ROAP signs a formal agreement with Maplecroft to build a Global Focus Model (GFM) based on their indexes. The GFM is only ever published internally due to data restrictions from Maplecroft³⁹¹ ROAP notes that IM Contingency Plans made in the past couple years were of not a good return on investment. Best value comes from investing in p-codes of high-risk countries, encouraging HCs to invest in their own IM capacity, and creating relationships with HCTs & clusters pre-disaster³⁹² OCHA holds its first Reporting workshops³⁹³ ICT Humanitarian Emergency Platform is created and funded by the UN Foundation, Vodafone Group Foundation and WFP³⁹⁴ • Aims to optimize and standardize ICT solutions in emergencies; expand the pool of trained ICT experts; establish a network of stand-by partners ready for deployment; and enable immediate dispatch of ICT emergency responders Smartphones start becoming widely available to staff³⁹⁵ ODK (Open Data Kit) launches. Forms part of the makeup of Kobo Toolbox (2013)³⁹⁶

³⁸⁶ Interviewee 52, May 2023

³⁸⁷ Interviewee 49, May 2023; MiniD (Mini Directory) pictures ([PDF](#))

³⁸⁸ Crisis Mapping in Action: How Open Source Software and Global Volunteer Networks Are Changing the World, One Map at a Time, Patrick Meier, May 2012, Journal of Map & Geography Libraries, 8(2), 89–100. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15420353.2012.663739>

³⁸⁹ Common Operational Datasets by OCHA Field Information Services, 28 September 2021 ([PDF](#))

³⁹⁰ Humanitarian and Country Icons 2012 ([PDF](#))

³⁹¹ Interviewee 13, March 2023

³⁹² Written Respondent 01 received 5 April 2023

³⁹³ Written Respondent 24 received 20 April 2023

³⁹⁴ Global Partners for Emergency Communications - Vodafone Group Foundation and UN Foundation - February 2008 ([PDF](#))

³⁹⁵ Interviewee 10, March 2023

³⁹⁶ Written Respondent 25 received on 3 April 2023

Year	Milestones
	ActivityInfo concept is drafted and work on Version 1 begins in UNICEF DRC³⁹⁷ First ever cash transfer through mobile phones in disaster response by Concern Worldwide in partnership with M-PESA in Kenya³⁹⁸
2009	OneResponse Philippines launches in response to Manila flooding³⁹⁹ • URL: www.un.org.ph/response⁴⁰⁰ • Content is managed via FTP • Content is dynamically displayed based on the file system metadata⁴⁰¹ OCHA's corporate 3W is shutdown (lack of funding)⁴⁰² OCHA Guidance on <i>Field Map Production and Dissemination</i> is released⁴⁰³ Advocacy and Visual Media Unit (AVMU) is created in OCHA⁴⁰⁴ • ReliefWeb Maps merges with this unit in 2010 IASC Needs Assessment Task Force (NATF) is created⁴⁰⁵ • Time-limited and ended in 2014 The first International Conference for Crisis Mapping (ICCM) is held in Cleveland, Ohio, USA⁴⁰⁶ • CrisisMappers Google Group is created ACAPS is established to conduct independent humanitarian analysis to help enable better-informed decisions^{407 408} Creation of the Joint IDP Profiling Service (JIPS)⁴⁰⁹ • Supervised by a Steering Committee including DRC, IDMC, IOM, the Office of the Special Rapporteur on the Human Rights of IDPs, UNHCR, OCHA and UNFPA OCHA, WFP, World Bank and Google collaborate to collect aerial image in remote areas of the Philippines⁴¹⁰ • OCHA prioritizes area on Google Maps • Google flies the planes • World Bank arranges the shipment of the DVD from the planes to Manila • WFP processes the imagery
2010	Haiti earthquake • Use of modern digital tools/approaches as well as many previously "uncommon platforms"⁴¹¹

³⁹⁷ Interviewee 53, April 2023

³⁹⁸ Cash Transfers through Mobile Phones: An Innovative Emergency Response in Kenya ([Webpage PDF](#); [Report PDF](#))

³⁹⁹ Personal experience of author

⁴⁰⁰ www.un.org.ph from Way Back Machine ([PDF](#)) and [un.org.ph/response](http://www.un.org.ph/response) from Way Back Machine ([PDF](#))

⁴⁰¹ Personal experience of author

⁴⁰² Personal experience of author

⁴⁰³ OCHA Annual Report 2009 notes OCHA Policy on Map Production updated and rolled out to all field offices and shared with the United Nations Geographic Working Group and IASC Task Force on Information Management ([PDF](#))

⁴⁰⁴ Interviewee 43, May 2023; AVMU - Custom Product Request in 2010 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁰⁵ IASC Needs Assessment Task Force ([PDF](#))

⁴⁰⁶ JCU Hosts First International Conference on Crisis Mapping, Way Back Machine ([PDF](#))

⁴⁰⁷ ACAPS - About Us ([PDF](#))

⁴⁰⁸ Interviewee 54, May 2023

⁴⁰⁹ JIPS - About ([PDF](#))

⁴¹⁰ Personal experience of author

⁴¹¹ Interviewee 55, March 2023

Year	Milestones
	- Technology has become democratized⁴¹² and it has become clear that technology can help in a response⁴¹³ - OneResponse.info launches in Haiti⁴¹⁴ - Humanitarian OpenStreetMap Team (HOT) is created in response to the Haiti earthquake^{415 416} - The Standby Volunteer Task Force is created in response to the Haiti earthquake⁴¹⁷ - Attempts made to leverage Call Detail Records (CDRs)⁴¹⁸ - US CDC (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention) deploys 4 statisticians to support the assessment efforts. Arrived with Palm Pilots⁴¹⁹ - Diaspora heavily engaged in digital efforts, perhaps for the first time, to support the international community⁴²⁰ - Short-code (4636), used by Mission 4636 to aid relief effort, is quickly available for use because the Haitian politician using it had died in the EQ^{421 422} - Mapping in PowerPoint: OCHA enables sub-offices to map 3W data using basemaps in PowerPoint where non-IMers can easily 'draw' their own maps⁴²³ - OCHA appoints, for the first time, someone responsible for coordinating communication with the local population (gather & share)⁴²⁴ - ICT4Peace Crisis Wiki launches.⁴²⁵ Perhaps the first wiki used in this way during a major disaster⁴²⁶ - Computer viruses are rampant as people rely on USB keys to move information and data (vs more physical in the past) from machine to machine without protection. Creates a sort of "digital pandemic"⁴²⁷ - UNDAC realizes that a lot of work could be done remotely with good connectivity and would avoid laptops from "melting" in tents⁴²⁸ Pakistan floods - OCHA's first use of crowdsourcing to help with digital activities - Dynamic Mapping of River Levels⁴²⁹ - Conversion of Font to GIFs⁴³⁰ - Translating FTS data into dynamically created charts for embedding⁴³¹

⁴¹² Interviewee 39, May 2023

⁴¹³ Interviewee 48, May 2023

⁴¹⁴ Personal experience of author

⁴¹⁵ Humanitarian OSM Team Wiki ([PDE](#))

⁴¹⁶ Haiti 10 Years Later: Growth of a Humanitarian Mapping Community ([PDF](#)); [Project Haiti Video](#)

⁴¹⁷ SBTF to dissolve - from Way Back Machine ([PDF](#))

⁴¹⁸ Interviewee 22, March 2023

⁴¹⁹ Interviewee 22, March 2023

⁴²⁰ Interviewee 34, March 2023

⁴²¹ Interviewee 34, March 2023

⁴²² Photo: Haiti earthquake-Nico diTada on the airfield developing the shortcode ([JPEG](#))

⁴²³ Mapping in PowerPoint - Haiti ([PPT](#))

⁴²⁴ Interviewee 56, April 2023

⁴²⁵ Haiti Earthquake 2010: Critical information updates to ICT4Peace Foundation wiki – 17 January 2010, ICT4Peace, ([PDF copy of Wiki content](#))

⁴²⁶ Interviewee 48, May 2023

⁴²⁷ Interviewee 38, May 2023

⁴²⁸ Interviewee 38, May 2023

⁴²⁹ Email to CrisisMappers Group entitled "Requesting Assistance - from OCHA Pakistan" on 18 August 2010 ([PDF](#)) and Google Doc detailing the request entitled "Translating a Google Spreadsheet to a Google Map" ([PDE](#))

⁴³⁰ Email to CrisisMappers Group entitled "Requesting Assistance - from OCHA Pakistan" on 18 August 2010 ([PDF](#)) and Google Doc detailing the request entitled "Translating a Google Spreadsheet to a Google Map" ([PDE](#))

⁴³¹ Email to CrisisMappers Group entitled "Anyone want to help OCHA Pakistan with dynamic, online charting of FTS data?" on 21 August 2010 ([PDE](#)) and Google Doc detailing the request entitled "Translating FTS data into dynamically created charts (and beyond)" ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	IASC Guidelines on <i>Common Operational Datasets (CODs) in Disaster Preparedness and Response</i> is endorsed⁴³² OCHA's first Geospatial Data Manual released⁴³³ Humanitarian ID (HID) proof-of-concept built within 2 weeks and functions on a feature phone⁴³⁴ REACH Initiative launches⁴³⁵ <i>GIS Tutorial for Humanitarian Assistance</i> (GIS Tutorials) is published by ESRI⁴³⁶ President Obama requests OCHA's dashboard for his daily briefing on the Haiti earthquake⁴³⁷ Arabhum, a network of information officers uploading information for the countries in the Gulf, created by OCHA. Inspired by RedHum⁴³⁸
2011	<i>Disaster Relief 2.0: The Future of Information Sharing in Humanitarian Emergencies</i> report is launched reflecting on the Haiti EQ and future possibilities⁴³⁹ Digital Humanitarian Network (DHN) is established⁴⁴⁰ • "Digital Humanitarian" term/title coined at the OCHA Communities-of-Interest meeting just before the November 2011 ICCM meeting in Geneva, Switzerland⁴⁴¹ ReliefWeb launches on Drupal 7 (beta) becoming one of the very first websites to be powered by Drupal 7 at that time⁴⁴² OCHA Information Management Skype group is created⁴⁴³ OCHA IM remote support: first, formalized remote IM support provided to Cambodia response to produce a 3W in under 12 hours⁴⁴⁴ OCHA's first official collaboration/engagement with the Volunteer & Technical Community⁴⁴⁵ Libya crisis response • Volunteer-powered, OCHA 3W is produced for the first time⁴⁴⁶ ◦ In response to the Libya crisis, volunteers collect 3W data from online sources (social media, news outlets, blogs, etc.)

⁴³² IASC Guidelines - Common Operational Datasets (CODs) in Disaster Preparedness and Response, November 2010 ([PDF](#))

⁴³³ Geospatial Data Manual - First Edition - December 2010 ([PDF](#))

⁴³⁴ Herison Andriamihaja interning with Andrej Verity in 2010 ([Screen capture](#))

⁴³⁵ Who We Are - REACH ([PDF](#))

⁴³⁶ Written Respondent 26 received 21 April 2023 ([PDF](#)); Amazon Books ([PDF](#))

⁴³⁷ Interviewee 57 March 2023

⁴³⁸ Written Respondent 08 received 11 April 2023

⁴³⁹ Disaster Relief 2.0: The Future of Information Sharing in Humanitarian Emergencies, 20 March 2011 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁴⁰ Digital Humanitarian Network - History and Today ([PDF](#)); Community of Interest Coordinators meeting notes from 13 November 2011 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁴¹ Personal experience of author

⁴⁴² Written Respondent 27 received 14 September 2023

⁴⁴³ Personal experience of author

⁴⁴⁴ Request made by Craig Williams. Coordinated by Andrej Verity. Email thread from 2011; [Visual](#)

⁴⁴⁵ Libya Crisis Map - Summary, by Andrej Verity, 17 May 2021 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁴⁶ Doing More With More - OCHA's Cooperation with the Volunteer Technical Community by Brendan McDonald and Andrej Verity, 2011 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	- Libya Crisis Map (LCM)⁴⁴⁷ launches as part of the above effort - LCM wins first place in the Technology and Innovation category in the 2011 International Association of Emergency Managers (IAEM) awards⁴⁴⁸ Data Scramble: <i>Coordinated Data Scramble</i> is formally named and begins happening with the help of modern technology (e.g. Skype, Google Docs, Slack)⁴⁴⁹ OCHA releases its first <i>Graphic Style Book</i>⁴⁵⁰ Inter-agency IM Skype group is created. Quickly reached the 600 participate maximum requesting special intervention from Microsoft to have it expanded⁴⁵¹ Common Operational Dataset (COD) / Fundamental Operational Dataset (FOD) Registry launches on HumanitarianResponse.info⁴⁵² <i>IASC Guidelines on the Humanitarian Profile Common Operational Dataset</i> is endorsed and released⁴⁵³ IASC IM Task Force dissolves as an official IASC group. Members continue on as the informal Global IM Working Group⁴⁵⁴. Lonely Planet signs an agreement with OCHA to grant access to their Guide and Language books to “a variety of UN agencies and government and non-governmental organizations” providing humanitarian aid in response to disasters⁴⁵⁵ Tableau is introduced into OCHA⁴⁵⁶ - Begins the shift from static products to online interactives - Eventually replaced in OCHA with Microsoft’s PowerBI OCHA discusses using the Cloud for hosting.⁴⁵⁷ It will become a reality in 2020 The Transformative Agenda attempts to address:⁴⁵⁸ - Strategic Capacity: focuses on improving the leadership and coordination of the system - Accountability to Affected Populations: introduces a stronger focus on ensuring that aid is accountable to the people receiving it - Simplified Coordination: Refines the cluster system to ensure it is more strategic and less bureaucratic in its implementation

⁴⁴⁷ Libya Crisis Map website, 22 July 2011, WayBackMachine ([PDF](#))

⁴⁴⁸ NetHope & Partners Win Technology and Innovation Award ([PDF](#))

⁴⁴⁹ *I scramble. You scramble. We all scramble for data!*, Andrej Verity, veritythink.com, 15 June 2016 ([PDF](#)); Coordinated Data Scramble History graphic, June 2016 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁵⁰ Written Respondent 29 received 20 April 2023; OCHA Graphics Style Book, 2011 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁵¹ Written Respondent 28 received 28 March 2023

⁴⁵² Written Respondent 28 received 28 March 2023

⁴⁵³ Interviewee 51, April 2023

⁴⁵⁴ Written Respondent 28 received 29 March 2023

⁴⁵⁵ United Nations and Lonely Planet launch partnership, 26 September 2011 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁵⁶ *Now You See It* course participation in Austria by author, October 2011

⁴⁵⁷ *What is the Cloud?* - Andrej Verity - OCHA - January 2011 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁵⁸ IASC Transformative Agenda ([PDF](#)); Transformative Agenda Chapeau and Compendium ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
2012	HumanitarianResponse.info (HR.info) is launched as the successor to OneResponse)⁴⁵⁹ IASC Operational Guidance for Coordinated Assessments is released⁴⁶⁰ Multi-Sector Initial Rapid Assessment Guidance (MIRA) is released⁴⁶¹ Humanitarian Kiosk - mobile app - launches. Powered by Dropbox as a backend⁴⁶² OCHA IPOR (Information Product Overview Report) established⁴⁶³ • Internal review that graded OCHA core products with an objective score to help ensure a certain level of standard in OCHA products • Covered: Humanitarian Profile Maps, Humanitarian Dashboards, Situation Reports, Flash Updates, Humanitarian Bulletins, and OCHA Websites • Stopped after a few years due to significant workload required⁴⁶⁴ Common Request Format (CRF) prototype is released in 2012 on HR.info⁴⁶⁵ • Aims to provide a common form that collects information from partners thus making OCHA more predictable and the information structured and re-usable • Pilots in South Sudan & Colombia • Discontinued (2013) given high degree of flexibility demanded in the field which the CRF could not provide Humanitarian Dashboard created as part of the NATF⁴⁶⁶ First ever official UN crisis map based entirely on social media data⁴⁶⁷ Flowminder is set up to analyze Call Detail Records (CDR) for humanitarian response purposes.⁴⁶⁸ Only ad hoc initiatives had existed before. OCHA begins the transition away from using MapCroc proprietary and expensive data for the Global Focus Model. Partnering with the European Union's Joint Research Center they compile open and free data indexes creating the eventual basis for INFORM (2014)⁴⁶⁹ Field Papers launches to help bring a paper-version of OSM into the field⁴⁷⁰ OCHA Mali provides an open work space for local OSM volunteers to come into so that they can upload their Field Papers to the servers and have it digitized⁴⁷¹ UN Security Council begins expecting heavy reporting requirements from OCHA in response to Syria⁴⁷²

⁴⁵⁹ Personal experience of author

⁴⁶⁰ IASC Operational Guidance for Coordinated Assessments in Humanitarian Crises, 2012 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁶¹ Interviewee 51, April 2023

⁴⁶² Humanitarian Kiosk, Dale Zak, December 2012 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁶³ IPOR explanatory graphic ([PDF](#))

⁴⁶⁴ IPOR 9 (2016) - drafted by not completed([PDF](#)); Interviewee 43, May 2023

⁴⁶⁵ Common Request Format and Development Sprint Presentation, 27 April 2012 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁶⁶ Interviewee 51, April 2023

⁴⁶⁷ How the UN Used Social Media in Response to Typhoon Pablo; 9 December 2012 ([PDF](#) | [Map & report](#))

⁴⁶⁸ Flowminder - About us ([PDF](#))

⁴⁶⁹ Interviewee 13, March 2023

⁴⁷⁰ About Field Papers ([PDF](#))

⁴⁷¹ Interviewee 28, May 2023

⁴⁷² Interviewee 22, March 2023

Year	Milestones
	Guidance for Collaborating with Volunteers & Technical Communities is released⁴⁷³ ArcGISOnline launches⁴⁷⁴ • Starts to shift GIS role from service provider to an enabler • More configuration of online tools so humanitarians can interact with GIS data • Shift from custom applications to <i>configuration</i> and system thinking GSMA Disaster Response Programme is launched⁴⁷⁵ Ground Truth Solutions is founded⁴⁷⁶ Power ballad and music video about former USG Jan Egeland released • Includes a photo of Jan and George Clooney looking at maps⁴⁷⁷
2013	OCHA adopts KoBo Toolbox^{478 479} The response to Typhoon Haiyan in Philippines introduces many firsts: • The first large-scale applications of remote IM support (with the OCHA skype group, DHN, etc.) and a model for capital-and-regional IMWGs⁴⁸⁰ • First L3-designated emergency for the UN/IASC system⁴⁸¹ • First use of a prioritization matrix⁴⁸² • Severity Estimation Estimate index is created from multiple data sources and mapped (by MSF working with OCHA and then later MapAction)⁴⁸³ • UAViator is created out of lack of drone activity coordination.⁴⁸⁴ Eventually leads to the creation of WeRobotics • First use of the MIRA⁴⁸⁵ • <i>OCHA Sudden On-Set IM Guidance</i>, drafted after the response, forms the basis for the OCHA IM Toolbox⁴⁸⁶ • First use of Artificial Intelligence by OCHA, in partnership with SBTF and QCRI, to scan social media⁴⁸⁷ • Helps catalyze the creation of the Philippines national Information Management Technical Working Group (IM-TWG) which includes 100+ members, has many signed MOUs, etc. The project was eventually cut due to presidential change⁴⁸⁸ West African Ebola Virus Pandemic breaks out • Local bikers carry GPS units to help geo-locate missing/misrecorded locations in Sierra Leone (2015)⁴⁸⁹

⁴⁷³ Guidance for Collaborating with Volunteers & Technical Communities, Digital Humanitarian Network; ([PDF](#))

⁴⁷⁴ Interviewee 40, April 2023

⁴⁷⁵ Dealing with Disasters: Technical Challenges for Mobile Operators - June 2012 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁷⁶ Ground Truth Solutions' About page on LinkedIn ([PDF](#))

⁴⁷⁷ Ylvis - Jan Egeland - released 30 September 2012, Accessed on 29 September 2023 ([YouTube](#))

⁴⁷⁸ KoboToolbox - About Us ([PDF](#))

⁴⁷⁹ Interviewee 52, May 2023

⁴⁸⁰ Written Respondent 09 received 13 March 2023

⁴⁸¹ Written Respondent 28 received 28 March 2023

⁴⁸² Interviewee 55, March 2023

⁴⁸³ Personal experience of author

⁴⁸⁴ Interviewee 59, March 2023

⁴⁸⁵ Written Respondent 28 received 28 March 2023

⁴⁸⁶ Written Respondent 28 received 29 March 2023

⁴⁸⁷ Typhoon Yolanda: UN Needs Your Help Tagging Crisis Tweets for Disaster Response, iRevolutions, 8 November 2013 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁸⁸ Interviewee 02, August 2023; Information Management Technical Working Group website ([PDF](#))

⁴⁸⁹ Nurses with tablets and bikers with smartphones join Ebola fight, Joseph D'Urso; 15 May 2015 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	- Open data is the undisputed primary source for geographical information (where as past emergencies it was alongside other, proprietary datasets)⁴⁹⁰ - Good PII practices, but results in IM teams not being able to do great analysis or trend work⁴⁹¹ ReliefWeb launches a dedicated mobile site⁴⁹² - Becomes the first consumer of ReliefWeb's API - Version 2 is released in 2018 - Decommissioned in 2024 <i>Field-Based Decision Makers' Information Needs in Sudden Onset Disasters</i> report is released⁴⁹³ <i>Humanitarianism in the Network Age</i> is released by OCHA⁴⁹⁴ <i>Humanitarian Decision Makers taxonomy</i> (visual) is published⁴⁹⁵ <i>Guidance for Collaborating with Formal Humanitarian Organizations</i> is released⁴⁹⁶ OCHA works with the Economist's Intelligence Unit around defining analytical priorities. These meetings and findings directly influence the creation of HDX in 2014⁴⁹⁷ HIC 2.0 concept is explored by OCHA⁴⁹⁸ - Concept is module - Includes several social aspects such as a "Coffee Module" what3words launches⁴⁹⁹ Opera - as part of the Multinational Coordination Centers (MCCs) for coordinating militaries' humanitarian efforts - launches and becomes the first one to produce a common operational picture⁵⁰⁰
2014	Humanitarian Data Exchange (HDX) is established by OCHA⁵⁰¹ - HDX is a direct result of frustration that very little of what OCHA reported data-wise was verifiable. - COD/FOD Registry transitions to HDX⁵⁰² HPC.tools genesis is from the Humanitarian Programme Cycle (HPC) kickoff workshop⁵⁰³ OCHA and QCRI (Qatar Computing Research Institute) sign an MOU to work on

⁴⁹⁰ Written Respondent 25 received 3 April 2023

⁴⁹¹ Interviewee 60, May 2023

⁴⁹² ReliefWeb Labs ([PDF](#))

⁴⁹³ *Demystifying decisions makers' needs in sudden onset disasters*, Andrej Verity, veritythink, 08 October 2013 ([Blog PDF](#) | [Report](#))

⁴⁹⁴ *Humanitarianism in the Network Age* (including World Humanitarian Data and Trends 2012) ([PDF](#))

⁴⁹⁵ *These are the Humanitarian Decision Makers*, Andrej Verity, veritythink, 3 September 2023; ([PDF](#) | [Taxonomy](#))

⁴⁹⁶ *Guidance for Collaborating with Formal Humanitarian Organizations*, Digital Humanitarian Network, July 2013 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁹⁷ Interviewee 57 March 2023; Written Respondent 30 received 16 March 2023; *Defining OCHA's analytical priorities: Research findings and initial recommendations*, 15 June 2013

⁴⁹⁸ *Humanitarian Information Centre 2.0 Blueprint* by OCHA's Information Services Section, 04 February 2013 ([PDF](#))

⁴⁹⁹ *'What3Words' Wants To Replace Postcodes With Words - For The Entire Globe*, Michael Rundle, Huffington Post UK; 07 February 2013 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁰⁰ Interviewee 27, April 2023

⁵⁰¹ ReliefWeb Labs ([PDF](#))

⁵⁰² Written Respondent 28 received 28 March 2023

⁵⁰³ Interviewee 52, May 2023

Year	Milestones
	technology initiatives including Artificial Intelligence for Disaster Response (AIDR)⁵⁰⁴ OCHA's IM Toolbox is launched on HumanitarianResponse.info⁵⁰⁵ ActivityInfo is widely deployed, for the Syrian crisis, as a partner reporting / 3W tool throughout the region⁵⁰⁶ It may have been the first use of an online 3W database at such a scale and so many partners. INFORM Risk Index launches. It is jointly funded across multiple donors, supported and used by many agencies⁵⁰⁷ Humanitarian Data Scientist role is defined⁵⁰⁸
2015	Nepal Earthquake - First Assessment & Analytics Cell, under UNDAC, is deployed⁵⁰⁹ - Used as best practice in developing UNDAC A&A Cell concept Humanitarian ID (HID) - for both contact management and authentication - is launched - First major disaster usage was Nepal Earthquake⁵¹⁰ - Promotional material included stop-motion Lego videos and Lego mini figures⁵¹¹ HNO/HRP InDesign templates are created for the 2016 HNO/HRP⁵¹² - OCHA transitions away from Word files (CAPs) into more standardized and well designed files for the new HNO/HRP ReliefWeb introduces Humanitarian Video → a curated collection of links to humanitarian videos posted online⁵¹³ Application Programming Interfaces (API) launch on HumanitarianResponse.info⁵¹⁴ and HID⁵¹⁵ Humanitarian Profile technical support package developed⁵¹⁶ Response Planning & Monitoring (RPM) launches as the first HPC.tools⁵¹⁷ The interagency Protection Information Management initiative is launched, generating standards for protection data across the humanitarian, development and peacekeeping nexus⁵¹⁸

⁵⁰⁴ Memorandum of Understanding between the United Nations and the Qatar Foundation for Education, Science and Community Development, signed 17 September 2014 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁰⁵ Written Respondent 22 received 20 April 2023

⁵⁰⁶ Interviewee 53, April 2023

⁵⁰⁷ Written Respondent 31 received 8 March 2023; Written Respondent 01 received 17 March 2023

⁵⁰⁸ *Humanitarian Data Scientist - who and how?*, Andrej Verity, veritythink, 20 December 2014 ([PDF](#) | [Graphic](#))

⁵⁰⁹ Interviewee 51, April 2023

⁵¹⁰ Personal experience of author

⁵¹¹ Humanitarian ID - The Arrival Scenario ([YouTube](#)) and Humanitarian ID - Fast and Easy! ([YouTube](#))

⁵¹² Interviewee 43, May 2023

⁵¹³ OCHA Annual Report 2015 ([PDF](#))

⁵¹⁴ Machines love to talk too: Introducing the HR.info API, WayBackMachine ([PDF](#))

⁵¹⁵ HID was built API-first and thus launched with the application - personal experience of author

⁵¹⁶ Written Respondent 28 received 28 March 2023

⁵¹⁷ Interviewee 52, May 2023

⁵¹⁸ Protection Information Management Training Resource Pack, 2018 ([PDF](#))

Year	Milestones
	ACAPS launches the first Humanitarian Analysis course⁵¹⁹ Materials are later used to build Analysis courses for OCHA & Red Cross Missing Maps consortium setup⁵²⁰ UN-GGIM (Working Group on Geospatial Information and Services for Disasters) is created⁵²¹
2016	Humanitarian Exchange Language (HXL) is launched by OCHA⁵²² HDX Lite is launched by OCHA⁵²³ ReliefWeb launches dedicated mobile apps⁵²⁴ - Decommissioned in 2018 COD Guidance is revised⁵²⁵ - COD scope narrowed - Core COD concept developed with focus on administrative boundaries and population - Change of term FOD (Fundamental Operation Data) Set to COD - COD Technical support package developed - FODs are dropped First <i>Guidance for OCHA IMOs Integrating Cash and Vouchers in Information Management</i> released⁵²⁶ DEEP (Data Entry and Exploration Platform - thedeep.io) is established, after the Nepal earthquake, by several agencies to strengthen collective sense-making and analysis⁵²⁷ The Grand Bargain, launched at the World Humanitarian Summit, is an agreement between donors and humanitarian organizations aimed to bridge the funding gap and improve aid effectiveness⁵²⁸: - Efficiency and Transparency: Commands greater transparency in how funding is used and shared across the sector. - Localization: Includes a specific commitment to put more funding and decision-making power into the hands of local and national responders. - Multi-year Planning: Encourages a move away from short-term, reactive funding toward more predictable, multi-year humanitarian planning.
2017	Centre for Humanitarian Data is opened, by OCHA, in Den Haag, Netherlands⁵²⁹ OCHA and UNFPA sign a joint letter of <i>Cooperation on the Core COD – Population Statistics</i>⁵³⁰

⁵¹⁹ Interviewee 51, April 2023

⁵²⁰ Interviewee 61, March 2023

⁵²¹ Working Group on Geospatial Information and Services for Disasters ([PDF](#))

⁵²² *HXL Version 1.0 goes live - #awesome*, Andrej Verity, veritythink, 21 March 2016 ([PDF](#) | [Postcard](#))

⁵²³ Written Respondent 32 received 6 October 2023

⁵²⁴ ReliefWeb Labs ([PDF](#))

⁵²⁵ Written Respondent 28 received 28 March 2023 and 20 April 2023

⁵²⁶ Interviewee 47, April 2023

⁵²⁷ Thedeep.io Website, Way Back Machine 29 March 2023 ([PDF](#))

⁵²⁸ The Grand Bargain (Official website) ([PDF](#))

⁵²⁹ Centre for humanitarian data: connecting people and data to improve lives, 05 January 2017 ([PDF](#))

⁵³⁰ Written Respondent 28 received 29 March 2023 and 20 April 2023

Year	Milestones
2018	Global Common Operational Dataset dashboard is launched - https://cod.unocha.org⁵³¹ ReliefWeb launches ReliefWeb Lite⁵³² • Prototype to test ideas and deliver them through a new technical framework; works as a Progressive Web App • Decommissioned in 2018 OCHA releases the song <i>Common Operational Datasets (CODs)</i>⁵³³ HICTF (Humanitarian ICT Forum) is organized by OCHA, and hosted by Google, • Aimed to bring together humanitarian organizations and the technology industry to find innovative solutions that will make the humanitarian response for people affected by conflict and natural disaster more efficient and effective^{534 535} • Is a sort of successor to the WGET (1996)⁵³⁶ Facebook announces their Disaster Maps project in conjunction with UNICEF, the ICRC and WFP⁵³⁷ • First significant data to come is for Hurricane Harvey in August-Sept 2017⁵³⁸ UN Geospatial Network is established by the Committee of Experts on Global Geospatial Information Management (UN-GGIM)⁵³⁹ • New iteration of the UNGIWG⁵⁴⁰ Strategic Framework on Geospatial Information and Services for Disasters is released by UN-GGIM⁵⁴¹ • Adopted by the UN Economic and Social Council in July 2018 under resolution 2018/14⁵⁴² OCHA and Lonely Planet extend their agreement to grant access to the LP Guide and Language books in countries where OCHA operates and/or deploys⁵⁴³ Global IMWG GIS sub-group starts⁵⁴⁴ ReliefWeb tests using Artificial Intelligence to help with tagging documents, to increase consistency and reduce human burden, as they are uploaded to the platform. Further attempts were made in 2020 and 2021⁵⁴⁵

⁵³¹ Interviewee 58, April 2023; Written Respondent 22 received 20 April 2023

⁵³² ReliefWeb Labs ([PDF](#))

⁵³³ Common Operational Datasets (CODs) animation ([YouTube](#))

⁵³⁴ Interviewee 62, September 2023

⁵³⁵ HICTF website capture, WayBack Machine ([PDF](#))

⁵³⁶ Interviewee 62, September 2023

⁵³⁷ Using Data to Help Communities Recover and Rebuild ([PDF](#) | [YouTube](#))

⁵³⁸ Andrew Schroeder received 30 August 2023

⁵³⁹ Geospatial Network on un.org ([PDF](#))

⁵⁴⁰ Interview with Steeve Ebener on 30 August 2023

⁵⁴¹ Strategic Framework on Geospatial Information and Services for Disasters, August 2017 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁴² Economic and Social Council July 2018 - Resolution adopted by the Economic and Social Council on 2 July 2018 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁴³ Broadcast message to OCHA personnel of 31 October 2017 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁴⁴ Written Respondent 28 received 28 March 2023

⁵⁴⁵ ReliefWeb Machine Learning Project document, August 2021 ([PDF](#)); Written Respondent 33 received 23 August 2023

Year	Milestones
	JADE (Joint Analysis of Disaster Exposure) is conceptualized and used by OCHA, PDC and WFP⁵⁴⁶ • Aims is to address the data gap for questions in the early hours of an emergency using state-of-the-art modeling, secondary data, and close cooperation with responding agencies⁵⁴⁷ • First used in the Sulawesi, Indonesia Earthquake response⁵⁴⁸ • Was almost called JEDI⁵⁴⁹ The IFRC launches the GO Platform to make all disaster information universally accessible and useful to IFRC responders for better decision making.⁵⁵⁰ OCHA releases the song <i>OCHA Information Management: The Big 5</i>⁵⁵¹
2019	Digital Situation Report beta launched by OCHA⁵⁵² IRIN becomes an independent (non-UN) newsroom and is rebranded as The New Humanitarian⁵⁵³ HDX Data Grid is introduced⁵⁵⁴ Humanitarian Kiosk - mobile app - decommissioned⁵⁵⁵ Cyclone Idai is perhaps the first time when (drone) aerial survey is used in a large way^{556 557} • Methodology: Kobo & grid system to aim at severity scoring that covered an area the size of Wales (done in 3 days). Put the form in the hands of anyone in an aerial vehicle. • Before: lots of air capacity, but independent assessment or reconnaissance which tended to focus on a specific point. Information and data was not structured such that it could be put together for a full picture IFRC's <i>Data PlayBook</i> and <i>Disaster Readiness Toolkit</i> are released⁵⁵⁸
2020	OCHA migrates a majority of its online platforms to the cloud, including ReliefWeb, HDX and HumanitarianResponse.info⁵⁵⁹ INFORM Severity Index is launched⁵⁶⁰ Global Humanitarian Operational Presence (3W) is launched - https://3w.unocha.org⁵⁶¹

⁵⁴⁶ Written Respondent 17 May 2023 ([JADE Flier](#), [JADE Infographic](#))

⁵⁴⁷ JADE Flier 2018 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁴⁸ M7.5 Sulawesi, Indonesia Earthquake Impact Analysis and Potential Needs (30/09/2018) ([PDF](#))

⁵⁴⁹ Written Respondent 09 received 17 May 2023

⁵⁵⁰ Interviewee 55, March 2023

⁵⁵¹ OCHA Information Management: The Big 5 ([YouTube](#))

⁵⁵² ReliefWeb Labs ([PDF](#))

⁵⁵³ The New Humanitarian - Our History ([PDF](#))

⁵⁵⁴ Introducing the HDX Data Grid: A way to find and fill data gaps ([PDF](#))

⁵⁵⁵ Personal experience of author

⁵⁵⁶ Interviewee 55, March 2023

⁵⁵⁷ Aerial Assessment Report - Mozambique - IDAI - 31-March-2019 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁵⁸ Interviewee 61, March 2023

⁵⁵⁹ Personal experience of author

⁵⁶⁰ Written Respondent 31 received 8 March 2023;

⁵⁶¹ Interviewee 58, April 2023;

Year	Milestones
	GIMAC (Global Information Management, Assessment and Analysis Cell) is launched through the Global IMWG⁵⁶² JIAF (Joint and Intersectoral Analysis Framework) is launched to help operations inform their Humanitarian Needs Overview (HNO)⁵⁶³ Digital Humanitarian Network scales back its digital coordination activities as more traditional actors had added and skilled-up in the space⁵⁶⁴ Standby Volunteer Task Force formally dissolves⁵⁶⁵
2021	OCHA releases their <i>Data Responsibility Guidelines</i>⁵⁶⁶ IASC releases <i>Operational Guidance on Data Responsibility in Humanitarian Action</i>⁵⁶⁷
2022	Creation of ReliefWeb Response (successor to HumanitarianResponse)⁵⁶⁸ <i>A Decade Later: Reflecting on Disaster Relief 2.0</i> report reflects on how well the 2011 Disaster Relief 2.0 report's predictions stood up and how things have (or have not) progressed.⁵⁶⁹ INFORM Climate Change Index is launched⁵⁷⁰ Humanitarian ID contact management functionality decommissioned⁵⁷¹ REDHUM is decommissioned⁵⁷² Major cybersecurity incident at ICRC⁵⁷³ Openness by ICRC prompts the community to realize that it can now be the target of such attacks
2023	ReliefWeb posts its 1 millionth report⁵⁷⁴ OCHA signs enterprise agreement with ESRI⁵⁷⁵ Multiple attempts had been made over the past 10+ years⁵⁷⁶ OCHA's Technology Governance Board is established

⁵⁶² Interviewee 63, April 2023

⁵⁶³ Joint and Intersectoral Analysis Framework (JIAF) 2.0: 3 questions for Herbert Tatham, OCHA APMB, 2023 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁶⁴ Personal experience of author

⁵⁶⁵ SBTF to dissolve ([PDF](#))

⁵⁶⁶ Data Responsibility, Centre for Humanitarian Data ([PDF](#))

⁵⁶⁷ IASC Operational Guidance on Data Responsibility in Humanitarian Action ([PDF](#))

⁵⁶⁸ HR.Info takes on a new form, ReliefWeb, 01 July 2022 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁶⁹ A Decade Later: Reflecting on Disaster Relief 2.0, Digital Humanitarian Network, 23 Aug 2022 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁷⁰ Written Respondent 31 received 8 March 2023

⁵⁷¹ Personal experience of author

⁵⁷² RedHum.org on Way Back Machine, 02 March 2023 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁷³ Cyber attack on ICRC: What we know 16 February 2023 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁷⁴ One million posts and counting ([PDF](#))

⁵⁷⁵ Written Respondent 35 on 18 September 2023

⁵⁷⁶ Personal experience of author

Year	Milestones
2024	HumanitarianResponse.info is taken offline, after 11 years, having been replaced by ReliefWeb Response⁵⁷⁷ ReliefWeb releases <i>Ask ReliefWeb</i> - an artificial intelligence-powered beta Question & Answer Chatbot for (individual) reports⁵⁷⁸ - Removed in 2026 ReliefWeb Crisis Figures project is closed down⁵⁷⁹ ReliefWeb launches a dedicated <i>Artificial Intelligence in Humanitarian Action</i> page⁵⁸⁰ OCHA's Centre for Humanitarian Data organizes the first Humanitarian Data Forum in The Hague⁵⁸¹ HDX Signals is launched⁵⁸² - A service that monitors key datasets (on HDX) and generates automated emails when significant, negative changes are detected HDX Humanitarian API (HAPI) is launched⁵⁸³ - a way to access standardized indicators from multiple sources to automate workflows and visualizations <i>Provision of Information Management and Analysis Organizational Review</i> about OCHA completed in December 2024⁵⁸⁴
2025	IASC launches the <i>IASC Standards for Collective Feedback Mechanisms</i>⁵⁸⁵ OCHA, together with the IASC and ITU, launch the <i>AI and Humanitarian Action</i> discovery series at part of ITU's AI-for-Good programme⁵⁸⁶ OCHA's Information Management Branch (IMB) is dissolved as part of OCHA's restructuring⁵⁸⁷
2026	Humanitarian Exchange Language (HXL) is retired by OCHA after 10 years.⁵⁸⁸ From the announcement: - The HXL standard was created over ten years ago as a way to combine messy data across spreadsheets. As technology and our humanitarian data ecosystem has advanced, we are exploring new ways to standardize data, improve interoperability and speed up data processing across data sources - HXL is an open standard and will remain available for organizations that wish to continue using it within their internal workflows

⁵⁷⁷ *HR.info - Farewell after 11 years of service* - email newsletter sent on 4 January 2023 ([PDF](#))

⁵⁷⁸ Announcing 'Ask ReliefWeb', 31 July 2024 (PDF | Avatar image); Presentation at AWS UN Cloud Alliance Day by UNOCHA ([PDF](#))

⁵⁷⁹ ReliefWeb Crisis Figures Data on the Humanitarian Data Exchange site is "Archived" ([PDF](#))

⁵⁸⁰ Artificial Intelligence in Humanitarian Action on ReliefWeb ([PDF](#))

⁵⁸¹ Humanitarian Data Forum ([PDF](#) | [Agenda](#))

⁵⁸² Introducing HDX Signals, Centre for Humanitarian Data ([PDF](#))

⁵⁸³ Announcing the HDX Humanitarian API, Centre for Humanitarian Data ([PDF](#)); HDX HAPI site ([PDF](#))

⁵⁸⁴ OCHA Provision of Information Management and Analysis Organizational Review - Final Report - December 2024; ([PDF](#))

⁵⁸⁵ IASC launches the IASC Standards for Collective Feedback Mechanisms ([PDF](#))

⁵⁸⁶ AI and humanitarian action: Unlocking the power of partnerships, AI for Good ([YouTube](#))

⁵⁸⁷ Extracts from USG Fletcher's message to staff on the OCHA reset on unochoa.org ([PDF](#))

⁵⁸⁸ Changes to support for the Humanitarian Exchange Language newsletter email from HDX on 14 January 2026 ([PDF](#))